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SPORTS

Roshibina wins silver in Asiad wushu

Rahul escalates poll panel row, calls for CEC's exit

Calling vote the foundation of democracy, Gandhi alleges systematic manipulation of electoral rolls to undermine democratic safeguards

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Congress leader and Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Thursday accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar of undermining India's electoral system, calling them *desh-drohis* (traitors) and demanded the immediate resignation of the CEC.

Addressing a press conference at the Congress headquarters in the Capital, Gandhi alleged that the Election Commission of India (ECI) had failed in its constitutional responsibility to protect voters' rights and claimed that he had sufficient information to establish that recent elections were manipulated.

"This is an attack on the Constitution and the legal

structure of the country," Gandhi said, alleging that those responsible would eventually face consequences.

Gandhi also said PM Modi and Shah would be investigated over what he described as actions against the country. Addressing CEC

Gyanesh Kumar directly, he urged him to "turn approver", arguing that doing so would constitute an act of nationalism. "PM Modi and home

minister Shah are both going to be investigated for what is being done. They are at the top of this conspiracy," Gandhi alleged. Gandhi played videos featuring PM Modi and Shah and referred to statements about the BJP remaining in power for an extended period and the slogan *Abki Baar 400 Paar*.

He argued that prolonged electoral dominance was inconsistent with what he described as the normal impact of anti-incumbency in a democracy.

Citing examples from Indian political history, including the period following the 1971 Bangladesh war, Gandhi argued that Governments traditionally face anti-incumbency pressures over time.

He questioned why, in his view, such pressures had not produced similar results for the BJP.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

BJP HITS BACK

A BJP rally in Amritsar Punjab on Thursday

PTI

New Delhi: The BJP hit back at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi after his news conference on Thursday, referring to him as a "frustrated leader who is not able to win people's support through democratic means."

The ruling party also charged him with making false claims. BJP spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi termed allegations

of vote chori (vote theft) baseless and said the Congress leader is trying to hype up a media report on differences within the Election Commission of India (ECI) and between the election commissioners because of electoral setbacks his party has been facing and because he is jealous of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

SENSEX SINKS 1,248 POINTS ON IRDAI REFORM PLAN

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Shares of banks, insurance, and fintech companies dived on Thursday after regulator Irdai proposed changes to the insurance distribution framework, including lower

Representative image

WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Expenses of Management limits and tighter controls on commissions, raising concerns about earnings and distribution economics of insurers and other related financial intermediaries.

DETAILED REPORT ON >> P11

The ByStander

E. Suresh

PIONEER IN SHORT

MAHADEV RACKET STILL ACTIVE: ED

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has told a PMLA court in Raipur that the Mahadev online betting network and related websites generated about ₹94,400 crore in alleged illegal earnings over the past decade. In its sixth prosecution complaint, the agency named 42 individuals and companies as accused, taking the total number of accused named across six chargesheets to 116. The ED has arrested 14 people and conducted searches at about 190 locations since opening the probe in 2022. The agency said the platform remained active through multiple mirror websites. It alleged that the network was promoted by Bhilai-based Saurabh Chandrakar and Ravi Uppal, who later operated from Dubai.

FSSAI MOVES TO BAN ANALOGUE PANEER

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has proposed prohibiting the manufacture and sale of non-dairy products being marketed as "paneer", as the food regulator steps up action against adulteration and misleading claims. In a draft amendment to the Food Safety and Standards (Prohibition and Restrictions on Sales) Regulations, 2011, FSSAI said the move was aimed at preventing consumers from being misled about a product's nature and composition. Analogue paneer is made from constituents not derived from milk. Products already licensed or registered under the "Analogue in Dairy Context" category would have to discontinue using "paneer" in their nomenclature, labelling or marketing if the proposal is finalised. FSSAI has invited objections and suggestions from stakeholders within 60 days. The Health Ministry said the proposed amendment would ensure food products are accurately presented and help consumers make informed choices.

Xi calls for stable China-US relations

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Chinese President Xi Jinping has called on China and the United States to remain partners, not rivals as he arrived in Washington for talks with US President Donald Trump.

President Donald Trump and China's President Xi Jinping participate in an arrival ceremony at Joint Base Andrews on Wednesday

AP

Xi and Chinese First Lady Peng Liyuan were received by Trump and US First Lady Melania Trump at Joint Base Andrews in Maryland. The welcome included the US Air Force Band and the flags of both countries.

In a written statement after his arrival, Xi greeted the American people and said China and the US are both major countries with closely connected interests. "China and the US should be partners, not rivals," Xi said, according to state-run *Xinhua* news agency.

He said the two countries' development goals could progress alongside each other and called for greater cooperation while managing differences and maintaining measured competition.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

SC asks ECI to settle TMC symbol row

The Supreme Court on Thursday asked the Election Commission of India (ECI) to apprise it of the timeframe within which it can finally decide the dispute between the two rival factions of the All India Trinamool Congress over its name and flowers-and-grass election symbol.

A Bench comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was hearing a plea of former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee against the ECI's decision to freeze the TMC's name and party symbol.

Referring to the delay in deciding the Shiv Sena dispute, the Bench sought an expeditious resolution and asked the poll panel for a time frame that would give both sides a fair opportunity to present their evidence. It asked senior advocate DS Naidu, appearing for the ECI, for the timeline and

posted Banerjee's plea for hearing on September 28.

"Find out, for final adjudication, how much time are you expected to take? Only for this limited purpose... reasonable time in which parties are given fair opportunity and you have time to apply your mind... but not too long," the CJI said.

At the outset, senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Banerjee, questioned the timing of the ECI's interim order, saying a new symbol was assigned to her party after the bye-election process had commenced and, consequently, she was denied an opportunity to avail legal remedies.

"Can the Election Commission delay matters, and then pass orders in the midst of elections knowing that I won't have a remedy," Sibal asked. He said the dispute had reached the poll panel in July and that it could have passed an order earlier, before the election process began.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Nine die as bus catches fire on Yamuna Expressway

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Greater Noida

Nine passengers died on a sleeper bus travelling between Delhi and Mahoba early on Thursday after it caught fire on the Yamuna Expressway late.

Police arrested the bus driver and conductor in connection with the incident. The duo allegedly refused to stop the bus despite being alerted about a burning smell and told passengers, "Die if you want to, but we won't stop the bus," according to the FIR.

At the time of publishing,

Firefighters at the site after a sleeper bus caught fire on the Yamuna Expressway in the Greater Noida area, killing nine passengers in Noida early Thursday

PTI

the police had yet to identify many among the dead except Devendra Bhardwaj, who was travelling with his wife Rekha Bhardwaj from the Hisar area to Mahoba,

according to the Jewar police. His age has not been made public. Rekha survived with injuries, including broken ribs, and is receiving treatment at Arogya Hospital

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Four servicemen arrested for gangrape in UP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Amroha/Lucknow

The Uttar Pradesh Police on Wednesday arrested four servicemen after a 23-year-old woman from Fatehabad in Haryana accused them of raping her at a farmhouse linked to an Uttarakhand MLA in Amroha. The police arrested the four men, including two UP police officers and two Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) personnel, within hours of the woman's complaint.

The accused include Hasanpur police station Sub-Inspector Sanjay Tomar, Head Constable Pramod Malik, CRPF Inspector Lalaram Yadav from Alwar in Rajasthan, and CRPF Head Constable Mohit from

Representative image

ISTOCK

Muzaffarnagar. The police allege the woman was first approached on 20 September by a friend who asked her to meet the accused CRPF constable to go on a trip to various religious sites in Amroha. She met him the following day in

Sonipat. Lalaram joined them on the way at Meerut. On September 22, they drove her to Hasanpur and picked up Tomar. The group arrived at the farmhouse and reserved two rooms, where first, Mohit, Lalaram and Tomar took turns to

rape her. When Pramod arrived, she pushed him out and locked the door. She searched for the telephone number of Amroha police station and called at about 6 am on September 23. Teams from the Hasanpur and Rajapur stations went to the place, secured her and took the four men into custody.

An FIR was filed under various sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita relating to abduction or enticement and gang rape, and all four individuals were sent to judicial custody, with their court appearance scheduled for Thursday. Tomar and Malik have been suspended, and departmental proceedings for their dismissal have been initiated.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Adani plans over ₹1 lakh crore investment in West Bengal by 2035

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

On Thursday, Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani announced plans to invest over ₹1 lakh crore in West Bengal by 2035.

Speaking at the foundation ceremony for a 2,000-bed hospital in New Town near Kolkata, alongside Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari, Adani stated the group will invest ₹4,000 crore in the multi-specialty Adani Arogya Mandir. The project is expected to generate 10,000 jobs.

Adani said that half of the beds at the not-for-profit hospital will be reserved for economically weaker sections eligible under State and

Union health insurance schemes. The facility will also include a medical college, along with research and care infrastructure.

"We expect to invest over ₹1 lakh crore in West Bengal by 2035," Adani said. He added that the investment will cover ports, logistics, power generation, transmission and distribution, roads, bridges, ropeways, green cement, and hyperscale data centres.

This marks the first formal announcement of the Adani Group's proposal to invest in power distribution, a sector currently monopolised by the RP Sanjiv Goenka Group through CESC Ltd in Kolkata and Howrah.

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari with Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani during a meeting, in Kolkata

PTI

CESC Ltd supplies power to Kolkata and Howrah, while the rest of West Bengal, including Salt Lake and New Town, is served by the State-owned WBSEDCL.

Explaining the rationale for the infrastructure investment, Adani stated that ports strengthen logistics, which attracts industry. Industry drives manufacturing, which requires energy, and energy supports digital infrastructure. He added that jobs multiply as this chain develops.

Adani described West Bengal as India's natural maritime and logistics bridge to Northeast India and Southeast Asia. He stated that the State has the potential to become one of Asia's

greatest integrated industrial and economic platforms.

He also announced the group's support for restoring the Writers' Building, revitalising Kumartuli Ghat, and promoting Kolkata's Durga Puja internationally. Adani referred to Mundra Port in Gujarat as the group's first *karmabhoomi* (land where one works) and expressed hope that West Bengal would become its second. He added that he visited the Kalighat Temple earlier in the day and prayed for strength to lead, the will to dream, and the energy to execute. He added that West Bengal's progress would contribute to "India's momentum".

CONTINUED ON >> P4

CM Rekha inaugurates mega health camp in Shalimar Bagh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurated a free mega health check-up camp at the Ayurvedic Hospital in Haiderpur, Shalimar Bagh Assembly constituency, on Thursday under the “Seva Sankalp Abhiyan,” while assuring slum residents in the area that not a single *jhuggi* would be demolished, with the tender process for permanent housing already underway.

The health camp is providing residents with a range of check-ups, medical consultations and health guidance in one place. The Chief Minister appealed to Delhi residents to make use of the free camp and get examined by the team of specialist doctors present.

The Chief Minister said healthy citizens form the foundation of a strong Delhi, and the Government’s effort is to bring healthcare services closer to people rather than confining them to hospitals,



ensuring timely check-ups, illness identification and medical advice.

During the programme, the Chief Minister interacted with slum residents and gave a clear assurance on their housing concerns, saying the Government is working to provide better housing to people who have lived in difficult conditions for years.

She said the tender process for constructing housing for *jhuggi* residents in AU Block

and AO Block in Haiderpur has already begun in the first phase, with suitable sites around these areas being identified for construction. In the second phase, *jhuggis* around the Ayurvedic Hospital area will be included, with suitable nearby land being sought so residents can get better housing close to their current location.

The Chief Minister said the Government’s aim was not to remove people but to improve

their lives. She listed development works underway in the area, including new toilets, water ATMs for clean drinking water, Atal Canteens, new sewer lines, water pipelines and street lights. To widen roads, officials are removing old structures and garbage bins and replacing them with new toilets and garbage bins.

The Chief Minister said Haiderpur had long needed a large school up to Class 12, with children currently having to travel elsewhere for education and documentation requirements. Around 5,000 square yards of land has been made available for the new school, with the tender process being prepared.

A tender has also been issued for a new community centre in the area, which residents will be able to use for weddings and social functions once completed. Work is also underway on a new Chhath ghat along the canal to provide better facilities during the Chhath festival.

Sandhu inaugurates Sadbhavana Sammelan at Gandhi Ashram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu inaugurated the Sadbhavana Sammelan at the historic Gandhi Ashram of the Harijan Sevak Sangh at Kingsway Camp on Thursday. The event draws a direct parallel between the Sangh’s founding legacy and his own grandfather

Sardar Teja Singh Samundri’s lifelong fight against caste barriers and untouchability. The event was held in the presence of Harijan Sevak Sangh National President Professor (Dr) Sankar Kumar Sanyal, along with other distinguished dignitaries and guests.

Sandhu recalled that the Harijan Sevak Sangh was founded in 1932 through the efforts of Mahatma Gandhi, at a time when Gandhi had built a nationwide movement against social discrimination. He said that for Gandhi,



freedom and Swaraj meant treating every individual in society with dignity and rights, and that many of India’s leading freedom fighters had visited this very place to meet him.

Sandhu recalled that Pandit Madan Mohan Malaviya presided over the historic Bombay meeting where the Harijan Sevak Sangh was established, following the Poona Pact signed between Malaviya and Dr BR Ambedkar to address concerns of the Depressed Classes and build a society free from untouchability, exploita-

tion and segregation. He said Gandhi, Malaviya and Ambedkar, in different ways, were working toward the same objective: ensuring political freedom was accompanied by greater equality and dignity in Indian society.

Sandhu said he saw a similar connection in the life of his own grandfather, Sardar Teja Singh Samundri, an important leader of the Gurdwara Reform Movement and a founding member of the SGPC, whose work extended into social welfare, education and the fight against caste barriers.

DDA’s Rang Ras Rooh festival on September 26-27

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) will organise ‘Rang Ras Rooh’, a two-day festival celebrating World Tourism Day, at Baansera, near Birsu Munda Chowk, Sarai Kale Khan, on September 26 and 27.

The festival will offer a range of activities for families. The daytime programme will feature puppet shows, folk singing and dance, and magic shows. Children can enjoy games, a toy train and rides at Masti Ka Adda. Hunar Gali will offer hands-on activities such as pottery, block printing and mandala art. Visitors can also explore Chitthi Ghar, Bachpan Ki Dukaan and Yaadon Ki Gali.



DCPCR receives 377 complaints, 38 under POCSO Act

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights (DCPCR) has received 377 complaints, including 38 cases under the POCSO Act, from July through September, with the most complaints about the Right to Education (RTE), according to data released by the child rights body.

Of the total complaints, 206 related to RTE, followed by 87 concerning juvenile justice, 38 POCSO cases, 17 cases of missing children, 16 child labour cases, and 13 related to health and nutrition. The commission has also taken suo motu cognisance of 56 cases, it said on Thursday.

The North-West district recorded the highest number of complaints at 61, followed by North-East with 38, East 35, West 34, North 30, South-West and South 41 each, Central 25, South-East 24 and miscellaneous cases 22.

In the wake of the alleged rape of a 17-year-old girl at Astha Kunj Park, the DCPCR has also issued a notice to the deputy commissioner of police concerned, seeking an action-taken report within two weeks, said DCPCR chairperson Om Prakash Vyas.

During a press conference outlining the commission’s initiatives, Vyas said the commission has sent letters to the lieutenant governor, chief minister, and the MCD mayor/commissioner, advocating mandatory regular



self-defence classes in schools across Delhi.

Vyas also said the commission is conducting a city-wide POCSO awareness campaign for children, parents, and school staff, focusing on safe and unsafe touch, reporting offences, and mental health counselling.

He said the commission’s child beggar-free Delhi initiative focuses on rescue, long-

term care, emotional rehabilitation and mainstreaming of children into formal schools through coordination among different departments.

Under the initiative, the commission has created a mascot, jingles, a logo, and a slogan, ‘Bheekh Nahi Seekh’, for its Child Beggar-Free Delhi campaign, which will launch within a month, he said, adding that it also

launched a child complaint helpline (9220999390) on Tuesday.

“As part of another new initiative, the department will also hire children who were in childcare centres and have attained the age of 18,” Vyas said. The commission has also conducted field-level inspections of centralised kitchens, Anganwadi centres and food delivery systems as part of Rashtriya Poshan Maah to check the quality of nutrition being provided to infants and lactating mothers, he added.

In July, the Delhi Government reconstituted the DCPCR and appointed Vyas as its chairperson. Rahul Gautam, Kundan Kanskar, Swati Gupta and Monika Sharma were appointed as members.

CM honours anganwadi workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday felicitated Anganwadi sisters who have served children, mothers, and families at the grassroots for years. Paying tribute to their years of selfless service, the chief minister said these women carry out one of society’s most important responsibilities without publicity or the limelight.

According to her, Delhi has around 10,870 Anganwadi centres, and workers associated with Palna centres are also being included in this recognition initiative. Listening to the concerns of Anganwadi workers, the Chief Minister said the problems faced by centres operating from rented premises had

been taken up in discussions with officials.

The Government aims to develop Anganwadi centres in better, permanent buildings over the next two years. As the first step, the process of shifting centres to Municipal Corporation school premises has been started. Children at these centres will have access to facilities such as toilets, parks and space to play.

The Chief Minister said Anganwadi sisters have been serving society continuously for years without seeking the limelight. From caring for children and reaching out to pregnant women to conducting surveys, assisting with vaccinations, preparing data and ensuring that Government services reach families in need.

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e - TENDER

Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the work :
Tender No. T26P750004: Construction/ Modification of existing foundations for 500 MVA Tr. Along with auxiliary equipment foundation, firewall, trench, various other foundation, soak pit and connection with sump well, NIPFES, NCT, etc including demolition and dismantling work.
For complete details of the tender please visit following websites:-
<https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_2965334_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-0175-220926
Last date for bid submission:- **28.10.2026, 13:00 Hrs.**
All Corrigendum/Addendum/Amendments/Date of Extension/Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

AXIS BANK

Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wish Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301 Regd. Office: "Trishul", 3rd floor, opposite Samartheshwari Temple, Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006

Publication of Notice regarding possession of property u/s 13(4) of SARFAESI Act 2002
Notice is hereby given under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (SARFAESI Act) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, a demand notice was issued on the dates mentioned against each account and stated hereinafter calling upon them to repay the amount within 60 days from the date of receipt of said notice. The Borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of power conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 9 of the said Act on the dates mentioned against each account. The Borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount and interest thereon.
The borrowers attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.

Name of Borrower & Co-borrower	1. Date of Demand Notice 2. Date of Possession 3. Amount in Demand Notice (Rs.)
1. Ms. Devyani & Mr. Rahul Kumar Rathi (Borrower/Co-Borrower) Mortgage Description of Property Flat No -516, Tower-Sat9, 5th Floor, Situated At Blossom Street in Plot No- Gh-02, Sec 143, Noida, UP and Bounded As Under:- East: As Per Site Plan, West: As Per Site Plan, North : As Per Site Plan, South : As Per Site Plan	20-Jun-2026 22-09-2026 Rs. 16,31,846/- (Rupees Sixteen Lacs Thirty One Thousand Eight Hundred Forty Six Only)
2. Mr. Ashwani Kumar & Mrs Vineeta Malik (Borrower/Co-Borrower) Mortgage Description of Property : Villa No- 011, In Tower S3, At Up Country Situated At TS-1, Sector-17A, Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority, Noida, UP and Bounded As Under:- East: As Per Title Deed, West: As Per Title Deed, North : As Per Title Deed, South : As Per Title Deed	25-Nov-2025 22-09-2026 Rs. 64,89,889/- (Rupees Sixty Four Lakh Eighty Nine Thousand Eight Hundred Eighty Nine Only)

Place: Noida, Date: 25.09.2026
-SD/- Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

GOVT. OF ASSAM

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (BORDER ROADS), ASSAM, CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-3.

No.CE/PMGSY/01/2025-26/ 56

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Re-tender, Call 3A

The Chief Engineer, PWD (Border Roads), Assam on behalf of Governor of Assam invites Item Rate bids in electronic tendering system for Construction of Roads under Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana, PMGSY-IV, Batch-I, for the year 2025-26 (Re-tender, Call 3A), for 9 nos. of roads (Length = 21.964 KM) in 2 nos. of Groups and 4 nos. of individual packages in the districts of Golaghat & Lakhimpur, with an estimated cost of Rs. 1833.783 Lakhs (Approx, excluding GST) including Routine Maintenance for five years from eligible contractors registered with Assam Public Works Department (Roads) or contractors registered with other State/Central Government Departments, institutions, Undertaking and Authorities.

Further details like last date and time of bid submission, date and time of bid opening and other details may be seen and detailed tender document can be downloaded from
<http://pmgsytendersasm.gov.in/> from **28.09.2026, 11:00 hours.**

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, PWD (Border Roads), Assam
Chandmari, Guwahati-3.

DIPR/CF/PIO/1719/25-Sep-26

LOST & FOUND

Lost Original Agreement to Sell and Purchase deed executed on 27/05/1991 by Smt. Vidhya Wati in favour of Smt. Seema Kukreja in respect of Property No. M-39, Mg-40 Sq. Yds., Shastri Nagar, Delhi-110052 vide NCR Lodged LR NO. 658143/2026 Dt. 24/09/2026. Finder(s) Please Contact Smt. Seema Kukreja. Mobile No. 9312562221.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the general public under the instructions from and on behalf of my client, Sh. Sita Ram, S/o Late Sh. Ram Kumar, R/o H. No. C-538, Near Delhi Jal Board Pump House, New Seemapuri, East Delhi - 110095 as under: That my client's son, Sh. Deepak Kumar, daughter-in-law Smt. Anjali and their minor children, namely Master Dheeraj and Master Milan, are entirely out of the control and say of my client. Their conduct and behavior towards my client have been persistently disrespectful, uncooperative, hostile and unbearable. If anyone enters into any dealing, financial transaction or liability with the aforesaid persons, they shall do so entirely at their own risk, responsibility and perils. My client or his properties shall not be liable, answerable, or responsible in any manner whatsoever for any of their acts, misdeeds, debts, or defaults.
(VINOD KUMAR SHARMA) Advocate
Enrollment No. : D-3232/2010

PUBLIC NOTICE

Under instructions from and on behalf of my client Mohd. Hamid, S/o Mohd. Sulaheem, R/o House No. A-19, Gali No. 9, Village Wazirabad, Near MCD School, Delhi, do hereby notify to the public at large that the correct spelling of my name is "MOHD. HAMID", wherever it appears as "MOHAMMAD HAMID", "MD. HAMID", "M. HAMID", "HAMID", the same shall be read as "MOHD. HAMID". Similarly, the correct spelling of my father's name is "MOHD. SUALEHEEN", wherever it appears as "MOHAMMAD SWALHEEN", "MOHD. SWALIHEN", "MOHD. SALIHEEN", "MOHD. SUWALHEEN", "MOHD. SWALIN", "MOHD. SWALEHEEN", "M. SWALHIN", the same shall be read as "MOHD. SUALEHEEN". Similarly, the correct spelling of my mother's name is "SALAMAT BI", wherever it appears as "SALAMAT", the same shall be read as "SALAMAT BI". The public at large is informed accordingly.
JAVED KHAN, Advocate
Seat No. 9, B.S. Sherawat Hall, Civil Wing, Ti Hazari Courts, Delhi-110 054.

AXIS BANK

Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wish Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301 Corporate Office: 'Axis House', Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025 Registered Office: 'Trishul', 3rd floor, opposite Samartheshwari Temple, Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006 Also at: Axis Bank Ltd., Hall No-1, PM 182 / G.F., Gauri Residency, Chander Nagar, Gazitabad, UP-201011

Publication of Notice regarding possession of property u/s 13(4) of SARFAESI Act 2002
Notice is hereby given under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (SARFAESI Act) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, a demand notice was issued on the dates mentioned against each account and stated hereinafter calling upon them to repay the amount within 60 days from the date of receipt of said notice. The Borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of power conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 9 of the said Act on the dates mentioned against each account. The Borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount and interest thereon.
The borrowers attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.

Name of Borrower & Co-borrower	Date of Demand Notice/ Date of Possession/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs.)
1. Mrs. Rhythm (Borrower) W/o Mr. Anshuman Singh B-119, 6th Pilkhani Street, Sector Gamma-1, Kasana, G B Nagar, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201310. 1. Mr. Anshuman Singh (Co-borrower) S/o. Mr. Arjun Singh B-119, 6th Pilkhani, Street Sector Gamma-1, Kasana, G B Nagar, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201310 Description of Property : Flat No. 174, 1802, 18th Floor, Tower-T4, Global Hill View, Sector-11 Sohna, Gurugram, Haryana. Bounded As Under: East: As Per Site Plan, West: As Per Site Plan, North : As Per Site Plan, South : As Per Site Plan	20-Jun-2026 22-Sep-2026 Rs. 17,56,262/- (Rupees Seventeen Lacs Fifty Six Thousand Two Hundred Sixty Two Only)

Place: Delhi/NCR, Date: 22.09.2026
-SD/- Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Public at large is informed that my clients Satish Kumar S/o Pal Singh and Smt. Renuka W/o Satish Kumar, has R/O-118, Veena Enclave Extension, Nangloi, Delhi - 110041 have Disowned/ Debbed their Daughter VIDHI R/o Above Address from all their Moveable & Immoveable Assets & Properties also severed all relations with her due to her bad behaviour & misconduct anybody dealing with her will do so at his/her/their own risk & Cost my clients will not responsible for her any act, deed or dealing in any manner.
Dharamveer (Advocate) Bar Council of Delhi, T-3A, 1st Floor, Tis Hazari Court, New Delhi-110054

PUBLIC NOTICE

The general public is hereby informed that my client, Sabana Parveen wife of Habib Khan, resident of House No. 43-A, Block-B, Hari Enclave, Part-1, Kirari, Suleman Nagar, Delhi-110086, has disowned her son, Fardeen Khan, from all her movable and immovable properties and has severed all legal and social relations with him. Anyone entering into any transaction or relationship with Fardeen Khan shall do so at their own risk and responsibility; my client, Sabana Parveen, shall bear no liability in this regard.
Sanjeev Dwivedi (Advocate)

SMFG Grihashakti

Corporate Off. : 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-BLOCK, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051. Regd. Off. : Cornerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE OF 30 DAYS FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 READ WITH PROVISION TO RULE 9(6) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002.
Notice is hereby given to the Public in General and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below listed immovable properties ("Secured Assets") mortgaged / charged to the Secured Creditor, the Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. (hereinafter referred to as SMHFC) ("Secured Creditor"), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" on the date and time mentioned herein below, for recovery of the dues mentioned herein below and further interest and other expenses thereon till date of realization, due to SMHFC Secured Creditor from the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) mentioned herein below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of the Properties	Reserve Price : Earnest Money Deposit :	Date & Time of E-Auction	Date of EMD Submission
1.	Lan No. 605439511480916 1. Lulu Mahto S/o. Bhagwan Mahto 2. Sunita Devi, W/o. Lulu Mahto	All The Piece And Parcel Of Property Of Area Measuring 25.08 Sq. Mtrs. Having Floor 04(Ground Floor,First Floor, Second Floor,Third Floor) House No. B-175 Gali No. 8, B-Block Mahalaksmi Enclave Karawal Nagar, Near Jain Mandir, Kharsa No 48/ 171/11 Delhi-110094.Boundaries:- North-Property Of Others, East-Gali, South-Property Of Others, West-Property Of Others.	Rs. 31,50,000/- Rs. 3,15,00,000/-	26.10.2026 at 11:00 AM to 01.00 PM	24.10.2026

Details terms and conditions of the sale are as below and the details are also provided in our/secured creditor's website at the following link website address (<https://BidDeal.in> and <https://www.grihashakti.com/pdt/E-Auction.pdf>) The Intending Bidders can also contact : Ashish Kaushal, on his Mob. No. 8527134222, E-mail : Ashish.Kaushal@grihashakti.com, and Mr. Niloy Dey, on his Mob. 8655619157, E-mail : Niloy.Dey@grihashakti.com.
Place : Delhi
Date : 16.09.2026
Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

Office of The Superintending Engineer

9th Circle, Public Work Department Dehradun

Website - <http://pwd.uk.gov.in> E-Mail : sepwddun09@gmail.com

Letter No.- 6688/1C-9/2026

NATIONAL COMPETITIVE BIDDING

Date 24.09.2026

e-tender Notice(Short term)

The Superintending Engineer 9th Circle, Public Works Department, Dehradun on behalf of "Governor of Uttarakhand" invites short term tender in two bid system for the following work. Information regarding tender shall be available on <https://www.uktenders.gov.in> from date 25.09.2026

Sl. No.	Name of work	Earnest money (Rs. In Lacs)	Cost of Tender Document (In Rs.)	Validity of Tender (In days)	Period of Completion (In Month)	Contractor Category of Registration
1	Improvement work by BC (Bituminous Concrete) from Km 0.00 to 5.00 of Pashulok Barrage Road under Kumbh Mela Infrastructure Development work-2027.	6.50	5000.00 + 18% GST	90	03	Registered in 'B' & above category in Road works in Central Govt. /State Govt/any Govt. Undertaking

UPSIDA

उपग्रह राज्य औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
औद्योगिक रिजर्व, नवित्वाचारण। E-Mail: ed2@upsida.co.in

अवकाशकाठील ई-निविदा सूचना

एनए द्वारा सूचित किया जाता है कि प्राधिकरण को निम्नित्त उपरोक्त में निम्न औद्योगिक क्षेत्रों में निम्न निम्न निम्न एवं अनुसूचित कार्य हेतु सरकारी विभागों/सार्वजनिक उपक्रमों/निगमों/प्राधिकरणों/प्राधिकरणों/नगर निगमों में पंजीकृत कर्मियों/उपरोक्तों को अवकाशकाठील ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्रमांक	कार्य का नाम	आवेदक का क्रमांक
1.	Supply and Installation of CCTV and Annual Services Charges at Firozabad, Bhogana (District Mainpuri) Foundary Nagar, Agra Sikandra Site A, B and C, EPIP Agra with 5 years AMC.	82.41
2.	Supply and Installation of CCTV and Annual Services Charges at Mathura Site A & B Kosi Kothan I and II, Kosi Kalan, Mathura with 5 years AMC.	58.86

निविदा दिनांक 25.09.2026 को 11:00 बजे से दिनांक 01.10.2026 को 18:00 बजे तक अपरोक्ष की जा सकती है, निविदा दिनांक 03.10.2026 को 11:00 बजे या इसके समान यादों को स्वीकारा जा सकता है। निविदाकर्ता द्वारा अपरोक्ष समय पर की गई सूचनाओं में निविदा को करने के बाद 03 कार्य दिवस में पंजीकृत डाक/व्यक्तिगत रूप से कार्यालय में जमा की जा सकती है। नोट: 1. निविदाकर्ता अपनी निविदाओं में समर्थन कर सहित दरे अधिक कर, अलग से मात्र जीएसटी/सीएसटी देय होगा। 2. निम्न कार्य हेतु निविदाकर्ता को निविदा अपरोक्ष करी समय निम्न सूचना विभाग/उपक्रम/सार्वजनिक उपक्रम/नगर निगम/सार्वजनिक उपक्रम एवं Eligibility Criteria में अनुसूचित वर्गों के अपरोक्ष कर अतिरिक्त होगा, अन्यथा निविदा को Consider नहीं किया जाएगा। निविदा सूचना निम्न जानकारी website: www.onlineupsida.com पर स्थिति निम्न सूचना निम्न की website: <https://tenderup.nic.in> पर देखी जा सकती है। निविदा से सम्बंधित अधिक जानकारी हेतु की प्रवेश निम्न, प्रत्यक्ष की, दूरभाष नं 9927930700 पर प्राप्त की जा सकती है।
राष्ट्रीय प्रत्यक्ष, अवकाशकाठील, नवित्वाचारण

PUBLIC NOTICE

Respected Shareholders of, Swadeshi Entrepreneur and Farmers Cooperative Society Limited, Noida U.P., Reg. No. MSCS/CR/1549/2024 are hereby informed that the Annual General Meeting of the society is scheduled dated 30 Sep. 2026 (Wednesday), Time: 11:00 AM held at Pradesh registered address: 1st Floor, B 8/2, Sector 88, Phase-2, Noida, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201305, to transact the business listed in the Agenda of the Board Meeting.

AGENDA

(1) Address by Chairman.
(2) To discuss regarding requirement of Fund to complete on-going project of the Society
(3) Consideration of the audited statement of accounts, Audited report, Annual report, Compliances report.
(4) Approval of the Annual Budget, review of actual utilization of reserve & other funds
(5) Amendment of Bye-laws if any.
(6) Addition of other new 04 states (Rajasthan, Uttarakhand, Maharashtra & Haryana).
(7) Any other matter business with the permission of the chair
(8) Vote of Thanks.
Kindly make it convenient to attend the meeting.
Thanks & Regards!
Chairman
Swadeshi Entrepreneur and Farmers Cooperative Society Limited

For more information visit
www.sefco.co.in, E-mail: info@sefco.co.in & Contact No.: +91-120-3586471.

BABA FARID UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES, FARIDKOT

Corrigendum
M.Sc. (Nuclear Medicine) and M.Sc. Allied & Healthcare Sciences courses

Online applications were invited through University website www.bfuhs.ac.in for admission to M.Sc. (Nuclear Medicine) and M.Sc. Allied & Healthcare Sciences courses upto **23.09.2026** and **24.09.2026** respectively. Now the last date for submission of admission applications has been extended upto **30.09.2026** upto **12:00 pm**. Accordingly the entrance exam for M.Sc. (Nuclear Medicine) M.Sc. Biochemistry/Histopathology and Microbiology (MMLS) will be conducted on **5.10.2026**. Counselling schedule and other information will be uploaded on university website. Candidates are advised to keep in touch with website for further information.

Principal

3108/12/2026-27/15545 dated CHD : 24/09/2026

GOVERNMENT OF MANIPUR

EDUCATION ENGINEERING WING, EDUCATION (S) DEPARTMENT, MANIPUR
Babupara, Near D.C. Office (Old), Imphal West

NOTICE INVITING OPEN TENDERS
Imphal, the 24th September, 2026

No. EE-1/EW/1-13/Open/2026-27/03: The Executive Engineer, W.D. No. 1, Education Engineering Wing on behalf of the Governor of Manipur invites item rate tender in single cover/bid through open tender from approved and eligible contractors holding Civil registration (appropriate class) and Electrical registration (valid licence) under any Government Engineering Department of Manipur State for 4 (one) number of work at Dhanamangli University, Imphal West under the SASSI scheme. The tender details and documents shall be available from 25.09.2026 to 05.10.2026 at the office of the undersigned during office hours.

IMPORTANT DATES:
Bid submission start date: 25.09.2026
Bid submission end date & time: 05.10.2026 up to 1:00 PM
and the bids will be opened on the same day at 2:00 PM

VENUE: Office of the Executive Engineer, Div. No.1, Education Engineering Wing, Education (S) Department, Manipur.
Sd/-
Executive Engineer, Div-1, EEW, Edn (S) Dept, Manipur

PUBLIC NOTICE

General Public is hereby informed that the State Level Environment Impact Assessment Authority (SEIAA), has accorded Environmental Clearance for the Proposed Expansion of Commercial Project "GR Corporate Tower" Located at Plot no. 7B, Sector-18, Maruti Industrial Complex, Gurugram (IT/ITES), Haryana, promoted by M/s G R Infraprojects Limited, valid Proposal No. SIA/HR/INFRA2 /560380/2026 dated 16.09.2026. General Public is further informed that copy of said Environmental Clearance letter is available on the websites of <https://parivesh.nic.in/>.

For

M/s G R INFRAPROJECTS LIMITED

DDA mandates structural audit of pre-2001 high rises

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has issued directions for a mandatory structural audit of all high-rise buildings, including malls, hospitals, and educational buildings, constructed before 2001.

The move comes against the backdrop of recent building collapses, including the one in South Delhi's Satya Niketan, which claimed the lives of seven people. "The structural safety audit is mandatory to be carried out by all the owners of all high-rise buildings (15 metres or above) which were sanctioned before March 21, 2001. The structural audit is to be

carried out within three months," said a public notice issued on Thursday.

The notice said even if a building (sanctioned before March 21, 2001) is less than 15 metres in height but has high footfall, such as group housing, educational buildings, hospitals and institutional buildings, cinema halls and assembly buildings, the owners of such structures would also have to get the assessment done within three months.

According to officials, the notice has also been issued keeping in view the structural safety against earthquakes.

Due to its proximity to the Himalayas, the national capital is located in Zone IV,

which has fairly high seismicity where the general occurrence of earthquakes is of magnitude 5-6.

In the recent past, there have been building collapse incidents reported, which have claimed several lives in the city. The structural integrity of these buildings has come under question.

At Saidulajab in Saket, six people died after a building collapsed, and another building collapse was reported in Karawal Nagar; however, there were no deaths. According to officials, the notice was issued with earthquake-resistant structural safety in mind.

Because of its proximity to the Himalayas, the national



capital is in Zone IV, which has fairly high seismicity, where earthquakes of magnitude 5 occur frequently.

"Structural engineers empanelled with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Government institutes and other Government agencies can conduct structural safety audits for the owners," the order said. After the audit, the DDA said, owners of the buildings will have to carry out retrofitting and corrective measures. In case of non-compliance, the order said, action will be taken against the owners.

In the wake of the deadly earthquake in Myanmar last year, which claimed the lives of at least 3,000 people,

earlier in April this year, the Public Works Department also issued an order to survey and retrofit all the essential buildings to make them earthquake-resistant.

After the Satya Niketan building collapse, Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal Khattar has proposed safety audits for DDA buildings more than 50 years old. Under the proposal, audits could be carried out at 10-year, 5-year, and 3-year intervals. For new DDA buildings, a safety audit after 50 years is being considered. A redevelopment fund is also being proposed so that reconstruction can be planned before buildings become severely dilapidated.

Hindu college student, friend harassed in Mukherjee Nagar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Student accused the occupants of a car of making objectionable comments, abusing and attempting to abduct her

A Hindu College postgraduate student and her friend were allegedly harassed by some men travelling in a car in northwest Delhi's Mukherjee Nagar area. The accused allegedly followed them, abused them and tried to drag them into the vehicle. The incident took place around 9:30 pm on Wednesday, and police have traced the car involved. The woman — a first-year Master's student from the Hindu College — posted a video recalling the incident on Instagram.

According to a video posted on social media, the first-year master's student said she and her friend were walking when a white car pulled up and the men inside allegedly made comments. When the women objected, the men allegedly abused them and later followed them, she claimed.

The student further alleged that when she and her friend stopped to record the incident, the men also stopped

and attempted to pull them into the car. The men fled after her friend started recording the vehicle, she claimed.

The student also alleged that she and her friend went to three police stations over nearly four hours before their complaint was registered, claiming that they were initially told the incident did not fall under the jurisdiction of the police station concerned.

"I have visited 3 police stations in the last 4-5 hours. But they are not even writing an FIR...For the last 4 hours, my friends and I have been standing here.

But even after that, they have not taken any action. They do not care that I am standing here in the middle of the night," she claimed.

Police said they are also looking into the student's allegation that she had approached multiple police stations before the case was registered. The investigation traced the car bearing the registration number 'DL11CF4447' to the driver, identified as Naman Anil Kumar. He was accompanied by two to three other people in the car at the time of the alleged incident.

The woman in the video

claimed that the accused is a student of the Faculty of Law.

"Police launched an inquiry based on the complaint and traced the car allegedly used in the incident," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Northwest) Akansha Yadav said. An FIR has been registered at Mukherjee Nagar police station under Sections 78 (stalking), 79 (word, gesture or act intended to insult the modesty of a woman) and 3(5) (common intention) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Police said further investigation is underway.

This is not an isolated incident. Earlier, a 21-year-old woman was allegedly stalked and harassed by two unidentified men on a motorcycle, who purportedly rammed their bike into her scooter in south Delhi, leaving her seriously injured on Tuesday.

According to the woman's complaint, the incident took place in the intervening night of September 11 and 12 near Panchsheel Park Metro station in the Hauz Khas area, when she was returning home from her office in Saket.

Delhi to install 20,000 smart LEDs by Diwali

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh

Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh announced on Thursday that the Delhi Government aims to replace 20,000 old street lights with smart LED lights by Diwali. Under the smart street light project, the PWD plans to replace 96,000 old and dysfunctional lights and add 5,000 more street lights by January next year.

The Government plans to replace over one lakh old street lights with smart LED lights, with the entire target scheduled to be completed by January next year. The project has an estimated cost of around ₹473 crore, which includes five years of operation and maintenance.

"By Diwali, our target is to replace 20,000 old street lights with smart lights across Delhi. The biggest change will be the centralised monitoring system. Every street light will be monitored in real time, and any malfunction can be identified immedi-

ately. The system will also allow remote control of the lights, enabling faster response and maintenance," Singh said.

Lack of proper lighting on public roads has been in the news recently after the gangrape of a 17-year-old girl in Astha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Temple after dark on Monday. Students from nearby Lady Shri Ram College (LSR) took out a solidarity march demanding better safety for women.

The smart lighting project will also reduce the recurring expenditure on electricity and maintenance. The new system will bring a major

change in the way street lights are monitored and maintained. A centralised Command and Control Centre at PWD headquarters will monitor the functioning of the lights in real time.

Under the new arrangement, the control room will continuously track the status of street lights. This will reduce reliance on citizens reporting faulty lights and enable the department to identify and address failures proactively.

The Minister said the new system is aimed at addressing long-standing problems in Delhi's street lighting network, particularly the

presence of dark spots caused by dysfunctional lights. "Earlier, there was no mechanism for real-time monitoring. In many cases, the department learned about a faulty light only after receiving a complaint. With the new system, the department will know about the problem and can take action without waiting for a complaint," Singh said.

According to officials, replacing conventional sodium lights with energy-efficient smart LED lights is expected to save around ₹30 crore annually in electricity and maintenance costs.

"The payment mechanism has also been designed to ensure accountability from the agency executing the project. The private company installing the smart lights will receive monthly payments only after the installed lights are fully operational. This will keep the agency responsible for the performance, upkeep and timely maintenance of the lighting network throughout the contract period," he added.





प्रखर राष्ट्रवादी और उत्कृष्ट संगठनकर्ता

श्रद्धेय

पंडित दीनदयाल उपाध्याय जी

की जयंती पर

कोटि-कोटि नमन

“एकात्म मानव दर्शन के प्रणेता पंडित दीनदयाल उपाध्याय जी को उनकी जयंती पर शत-शत नमन। उन्होंने राष्ट्र निर्माण में अपना जीवन समर्पित कर दिया। उनके विचार देशवासियों को सदैव प्रेरित करते रहेंगे।”

-नरेन्द्र मोदी, प्रधानमंत्री

नरेन्द्र मोदी

प्रधानमंत्री

DIP/Shabdarth/Display/095/26-27

रेखा गुप्ता

मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली

IN FOCUS



A head priest displays a relic of Sufi saint Syed Abdul Qadir Jilani to the people during the saint's annual commemoration at Dastgeer Sahib in Srinagar, Jammu and Kashmir

PTI

Akhilesh Yadav boards PDA rath for Raebareli visit



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Lucknow

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday boarded a specially designed "PDA Rath", his mount of choice to bounce back from the two successive electoral reverses he has faced at the hands of the BJP, for a visit to Raebareli.

As part of his campaign for the 2027 UP Assembly polls, Yadav is set to traverse the nooks and corners of the state on the "PDA Rath" to connect with the politically influential voters of "Pichhda, Dalit, Alpsankhyak (PDA)" - the social coalition that has become a central plank of the SP's strategy.

The SP is yet to announce a detailed itinerary for a formal launch of Yadav's PDA Rath Yatra, but the BJP wasted little time in taking potshots at Yadav for his visit to Raebareli, a Congress bastion with Rahul Gandhi as its sitting MP, claiming the SP attempts to demonstrate the party's strength in a Congress stronghold.

Rahul escalates poll panel row

Gandhi further alleged that the Lok Sabha and Assembly elections had been rigged and repeatedly used the phrase *vote chori* (vote theft) to describe what he claimed was manipulation of the electoral process.

"The vote is the foundation of our democracy," Gandhi said, arguing that the Election Commission's role in protecting the vote was central to safeguarding the Constitution and the country's institutions.

He earlier said on X that the "enemies of the Constitution" had been exposed and that justice would be served. On Wednesday, Gandhi had also alleged that "vote chori" constituted a direct attack on the Constitution and accused the BJP, RSS and Election Commission of committing an act of treason.

Gandhi's latest remarks followed a report by *The Indian Express* that highlighted disagreements among the three-member ECI over issues related to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, electoral software and handling of responsibilities. According to the newspaper's report, Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had raised objections on record at least 14 times over 10 months regarding decisions and orders related to the SIR process, including four objections on a single day. The report said the two commissioners objected to certain decisions because they were taken without their knowledge.

BJP hits back at Rahul Gandhi

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters in New Delhi, Trivedi also called Gandhi a master manipulator and alleged that the PPT presentation the Congress leader made at his press conference on Thursday came from unknown and dubious sources. "All decisions (at the Election Commission) were taken unanimously. There is no evidence that the decisions were taken by majority," Trivedi said.

The BJP leader questioned the authenticity of the report published in *The Indian Express*. He argued that the news report does not carry a comment, even off the record, from the Election Commission or any of the election commissioners. "What is the basis of the report?" he asked.

Housing projects launched in Lucknow

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday launched the foundation-laying and plot registration process for the Lucknow Development Authority's Varun Vihar and Naimish Nagar housing schemes, spread over 10,680 acres and involving an estimated investment of ₹12,000 crore.

He also laid the foundation stone for five proposed multi-storey apartment projects, estimated to cost ₹2,166 crore, at an event in Lucknow.

Addressing the gathering, Adityanath said the two housing projects would provide planned residential facilities to lakhs of people while helping expand Lucknow in an organised manner. "Unplanned development



often creates problems. People buy land at different places, but there is no electricity or water supply, sewerage or other facilities. Waterlogging can also force people to live in difficult conditions," he said.

According to Adityanath, the Varun Vihar scheme will

be developed over more than 6,500 acres and is expected to provide residential facilities to more than six lakh people. The Naimish Nagar scheme will cover around 4,100 acres and is expected to benefit more than four lakh people, he said. "Naimisharanya is a

symbol of our heritage. According to our tradition, 88,000 sages undertook penance and preserved India's knowledge heritage there thousands of years ago," he said. Adityanath assured farmers whose land would be acquired for the projects that they would receive proper compensation. "There will be no middlemen between the LDA and the farmers. No brokerage will be allowed," he said. Referring to the compensation paid to farmers, he cited examples of beneficiaries who, he said, received compensation ranging from around Rs 1.96 crore to Rs 3.13 crore and subsequently purchased land elsewhere or invested their money. The chief minister cited the Tata automobile plant and Ashok Leyland's electric vehicle manufacturing facility as

examples of Lucknow's expanding industrial base. Adityanath also highlighted the expansion of the airport and metro, construction of the Kisan Path and Green Corridor, and improved road connectivity around the state capital.

He said the Government was working towards developing Lucknow not merely as a city or district but as a State Capital Region (SCR), with Lucknow, Unnao, Hardoi, Sitapur, Barabanki and Rae Bareilly linked through planned regional development.

Referring to defence manufacturing, Adityanath said Lucknow was now also emerging as a centre for production of the BrahMos missile. "Earlier, people used to associate Lucknow with country-made pistols and bombs, but now BrahMos missiles are being manufactured here," he said.

Hindu college staff association condemns notices to Ratan Lal, 2 others

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The Hindu College Staff Association passed a resolution on Thursday condemning the college governing body for issuing show-cause notices to three of its members, including its president, Ratan Lal. The action occurred amid an ongoing dispute over alleged irregularities in admissions and subsequent disciplinary action against faculty members.

The Hindu College Staff Association (HCSA) said it will provide legal aid to the faculty members facing disciplinary proceedings. The HCSA wondered how, when the association unanimously raised concerns about "irregularities in admissions" at its meetings on August 18 and September 8, three of its members



were targeted. It described the show-cause notices as an attempt to "strip the HCSA and its executive of their identity and legitimacy" in the college's functioning. The HCSA took note of reports of the administration's intimidation of student

and teacher protesters and those acting on its behalf and resolved not to accept any "punitive/disciplinary action".

The HCSA has authorised its executive to decide the future course of action regarding the notices. As part of its resolution, the association decided to remove Hindu College Principal Anju Srivastava and Vice-Principal Reena Jain from HCSA membership.

Hindu College Principal Anju Srivastava said, "The decision to send the show-cause notices was taken by the governing body, following which the staff association had its emergency meeting today. The show-cause notices are simply a chance to open the door for discussion, and, as per the rules, they are expected to submit their explanations within seven days of receipt of the notice." The devel-

opment comes against the backdrop of a dispute over admissions under the extracurricular activities (ECA) and sports categories at the college. At an emergency meeting on August 18, the staff association alleged "over-admissions" in select departments and accused the college principal of playing a "dubious role" in facilitating the admissions.

It also alleged that the college's statutory bodies were bypassed.

The principal rejected the allegations, saying Delhi University made the allocations directly and that she had no role beyond final approvals. The Governing Body subsequently issued show-cause notices dated September 8 to Lal and Vijayan, which, according to the professors, reached them on Wednesday. In the notice to Lal, the Governing Body referred to his

August 18 statement and subsequent communications, alleging that he had made statements that discredited the college and brought its name into disrepute. It cited his allegations of procedural and rule violations in admissions and alleged that he had violated the code of conduct applicable to DU teachers.

In Vijayan's case, the Governing Body referred to an August 21 email he sent to faculty members and alleged that it contained derogatory and offensive characterisations of fellow faculty members. Both notices directed the faculty members to submit their explanations within seven working days of receiving the notice, failing which disciplinary action could be taken for alleged "gross misconduct, indiscipline and insubordination".

ED arrests kingpin in cryptocurrency fraud, money-laundering case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

■ New Delhi

The Directorate of Enforcement (ED)'s Chennai Zonal Office II has arrested Syed Usman, also known as Babu, and Dhamodharan Balachandran on 22 September 2026 under Section 19 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

The Directorate brought both accused before the Special Court, PMLA, which granted three days of judicial custody.

The arrests are part of a money-laundering investigation relating to the Hashpe

cryptocurrency fraud.

The investigation started

with an FIR filed by the Cyber Crime Police Station in Puducherry under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, and the Information Technology Act, 2000. The police found that Syed Usman, Imran Basha, and their associates set up an investment scheme known as Hashpe, presenting it as a cryptocurrency trading platform. They lured investors with promises of substantial returns through a supposed cryptocurrency called TCX. They obtained the money through bank transfers, cryptocurrency, and cash.

To make the scheme

appear credible, the accused arranged a launch event and a ceremony awarding cars, which included Bollywood celebrities.

To attract more investors, the accused used referral commissions, promoted the scheme on social media, and held an event on a cruise ship in Mumbai.

The total amount of ₹146 crore was raised through three main sources: ₹16 crore obtained in cash as part of the proceeds of crime, ₹10.52 crore which was credited to a bank account under the name of Hify Circle, and ₹120 crore in the form of TCX coins. Syed



Usman, together with Dhamodharan, was instrumental in obtaining, stacking and redirecting the money earned through criminal activity.

Usman looked after the large amounts of cash and managed the Hify Circle bank

account, which received money from investors. Dhamodharan designed and managed the Hashpe software, the database, and the cryptocurrency operations, including the platform's wallet functions.

The funds were channelled into the private bank accounts of Syed Usman, Dhamodharan, members of their families and other associated organisations. They also put some of the money into cryptocurrency and into property. They then used the money to buy cars for certain investors, pay for appearances by Bollywood celebri-

ties, organise cruises and large public events, give gold as gifts, and fund other luxurious personal expenses.

On 1 September 2026, the ED carried out searches at 11 locations in Chennai, Coimbatore and Kolkata. The two other persons accused in the case, Imran Basha and Hitesh Kumar, are currently in judicial custody. The funds moved in a consistent pattern: aggressive promotion, raising money from investors, routing it through multiple accounts and wallets, and finally directing it into personal assets and on to extravagant spending.

FROM PAGE - 1

time since 1962 that a US president personally welcomed a foreign leader at the base. In 1962, President John F. Kennedy received British Prime Minister Harold Macmillan there.

Xi said the visit would produce results through efforts by both sides and that stronger cooperation could benefit the people of China and the US while contributing to global peace.

The Chinese delegation includes Cai Qi, a member of the Communist Party of China's Politburo Standing Committee and director of the party's General Office, and Foreign Minister Wang Yi.

Adani plans over ₹1 lakh crore investment...

CM Adhikari on Thursday said the State Government was working closely with the Adani Group to reshape the State's industrial and healthcare landscape.

Adhikari explained that after becoming CM in May, he requested Adani to invest in the State. He also urged Adani to help revive the state's industrial sector, and Adani assured him of full support, the CM said.

"This is a historic day. The facility will be a super-speciality hospital and a centre for medical education and research. It will help train future doctors and benefit the eastern and northeastern regions," he said.

Adhikari said that the campus will eventually develop into a fully integrated healthcare city, featuring residential facilities for students, hostels, staff quarters, and advanced infrastructure and utility systems.

He added that the facility is expected to attract medical tourists from northeastern states and neighbouring countries.

SC asks ECI to settle TMC symbol row

"The intent of the Election Commission is to leave me without a remedy," he said.

The Bench, however, questioned what the ECI could have done after receiving nominations from candidates belonging to both factions, each claiming to be the genuine TMC.

Justice Bagchi said that the election schedule had already been notified and said the ECI's interim arrangement for the notified bye-elections "cannot be touched" at this stage.

He said the immediate issue was whether the ECI had reached a prima facie conclusion that an interim arrangement was necessary to "place both the rival groups on even keel".

"There was no consideration at all," Sibal said, adding that Banerjee was not seeking to challenge the interim arrangement at this stage and instead urged the Bench to direct the poll panel to complete the adjudication in October.

He also pointed to the forthcoming local body elections in West Bengal.

Appearing for the rival faction led by Ritabrata Banerjee, senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi said the poll panel had passed similar interim orders in earlier party-symbol disputes, including the Shiv Sena matter. "We have seen what delay does in Shiv Sena," Justice Bagchi said.

Rohatgi, however, submitted that an October deadline would be too short and sought more "breathing time" for the rival faction to present its case. Senior advocate NK Kaul, also appearing for the Ritabrata faction, said the dispute involved complex factual issues and would require affidavits and evidence from the parties.

He said that one month would not be sufficient for a proper adjudication.

The ECI on September 17 barred the two rival factions from using the TMC name and the symbol for the forthcoming elections.

As an interim arrangement, the poll panel allotted the name 'Mamata All India Trinamool Congress' and the 'Football Player' symbol to the Mamata Banerjee-led faction, while the Ritabrata Banerjee-led faction was allotted the name 'Democratic Trinamool Congress' and the 'Envelope' symbol.

The poll panel, after hearing leaders of the two factions, said the matter required substantive determination under the provisions of the Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order 1968.

Four servicemen arrested for gangrape

A report suggesting action against the two CRPF personnel has been forwarded to their headquarters. Police are questioning the farmhouse manager.

The investigation is still ongoing into how the rooms were booked, the precise order of events at the property, and the roles of everyone who was there that night, a senior Amroha police official said.

Sudhir Walia under EOW probe in ₹5,000 crore Jaypee insolvency

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Mumbai

Businessman Sudhir Walia is under investigation by the Mumbai Police Economic Offences Wing (EOW) in a dispute over the Jaypee Infratech Ltd insolvency process, involving assets and interests estimated at about ₹5,000 crore.



An FIR registered on September 9, 2026, at Matunga Police Station and later taken over by the EOW names Walia, Khyati Walia, Ramesh Madanlal Jain, Lakshdeep Investments and Finance Pvt Ltd and Lakshdeep Infrastructure and Holdings Private Limited.

They have been booked under Section 66(C) of the Information Technology Act and Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita provisions on cheating, forgery, use of forged documents and criminal conspiracy. The complainant, Vijaykumar Mohanlal Parekh, a director of Suraksha Realty Ltd, alleges that the Walia Group used SRL's name, letterhead, seal, records and digital credentials without authority. SRL was incorporated in 2008 and, according to the complaint, was jointly owned by the Parekh and Walia groups.

Parekh says his group and Virtual Finance later decided not to proceed with the JIL resolution plan and informed the Walia side. He alleges that the Walia Group still continued through SRL and Lakshdeep. In February 2019 the two companies formed a consortium with SRL as the lead member.

The consortium was declared the successful resolution applicant. The NCLT approved the plan in March 2023 and the NCLAT upheld it in May 2024.

The core issue for police is authorisation. Parekh claims no SRL board meeting was held on the JIL matter after the families fell out and that SRL never authorised anyone to implement the plan.

Nine die as bus catches fire on Yamuna...

A partial list of passengers issued by the administration names, among others, Veerendra Kumar Singh, Vishwamitra Yadav, Omji Gupta, Ankit Rajput, Praveesh Kumar, Manav Dwivedi, Rony Vishwas, Prabhudayal Gupta, Utkarsh Gupta, Sipsal Singh, Sunil Kumar, Rinki Rajput, Ravindra Rajput, Vikas Kumar, Mukesh Goswami, Harisharan Gupta and Usha Gupta.

The bus, registered in Bihar as BR-32-PA-8647 and operated by Raj Kalpana Travels, set off from Kashmere Gate around 9pm on Wednesday with about 30 to 35 passengers on board. The fire broke out at around 11.30pm near the 33km point in Jewar. Over 20 people managed to escape, some by jumping from the vehicle. Nine people were found dead inside the bus.

Suneel Kumar of Hamirpur, whose complaint led to the FIR being filed at the Jewar police station, said the passengers initially objected to both the driver and the conductor smoking inside the cabin. They allegedly laughed and told the passengers to keep quiet. A strong smell of burning then came from the cabin, and the driver treated it as something normal and did not stop.

Upon the outbreak of flames close to the driver's seat and as people were screaming, the crew is alleged to have said, "If you want to die, then die; we won't stop the bus." Rinki Rajput, who was en route to Rath, said that she was asleep when someone knocked on her berth and that she ran out without her shoes, taking only her phone. Rekha Bhardwaj said that she fell while running away and was trampled; when she got to the road, she could not locate her husband.

Investigators are looking into a possible spark or explosion in the air-conditioning system, blocked emergency exits, and flammable material in the luggage compartment. The bus also had several overdue traffic fines. DCP Traffic Central Range K Ramesh said that the bus had nine challans in Delhi, mainly for overspeeding and for improper parking.

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath have announced ₹2 lakh for each family who has lost a loved one and ₹50,000 for those who have been injured.

INDIA ROARS. LOUDER THAN EVER...



PLI Schemes have Transformed the Landscape

- ₹23.8 lakh crore worth of production/sales
- ₹15.5+ lakh crore worth of exports
- 14.6 lakh jobs created

India's Big Leap in Manufacturing

- 99.2% of mobile phones used in the country are now made in India
- Electronics manufacturing rose nearly 6 times to ₹13.11 lakh crore from ₹1.90 lakh crore in 2014 creating over 25 lakh jobs
- Defence production increased over 280% to ₹1.78 lakh crore from ₹46,400 crore in 2014

The Word 'Startup' Is Now Linked to India's Identity

- More than 2.5 lakh startups
- Around 50% of them are from Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities
- More than 25 lakh jobs created by startups

Big Vision, High Ambitions

- 84% surge in exports to \$863 billion from \$468 billion in 2014
- ₹43 lakh crore push for infrastructure projects attracting investments
- 20 Industrial Smart Cities approved by Government of India
- In 2025-26, 1.40+ lakh patents filed; highest in two decades

A Market for Every Product

- Under One District One Product (ODOP), 1,244 unique products from 773 districts have been selected, and artisans are being supported
- Over 470 crore orders placed through the Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC), giving a big boost to small enterprises



“Now India is writing a new saga of manufacturing from chip to ship.”

- Narendra Modi



ECINet is decentralised, only designated officials have access, says ECI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Election Commission of India's ECINet is a "decentralised" platform where statutory functions can only be performed by the designated election officials and not by anyone at the poll body's headquarters, ECI officials said on Thursday, citing official documents.

The assertion comes amid questions over the functioning of the ECI's digital systems

following an Indian Express report that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi had raised concerns over the "gradual centralisation" of the electoral roll database and the access available to officials in states.

The officials said booth level officers (BLOs), assistant electoral registration officers (AEROs), electoral registration officers (EROs), district election officers (DEOs) and chief electoral officers

(CEOs) perform their respective statutory functions on ECINet using unique IDs and passwords. "No one else can perform their statutory function on ECINet, including any other officer of the ECI," an official said.

Cybersecurity for the platform is, however, provided centrally by the ECI. Officials said this was necessary to protect it from malicious attacks, citing around 68 lakh such attempts on counting day during the assembly elections earlier this



year. ERONET, the ECI's earlier electoral roll management system, has now been integrated into the broader ECINet platform. Official documents refer to it as the "Electoral Roll module of ECINET Portal (previously ERONET)".

The issue has come into focus following reports that EROs in Goa found 97 voters eligible during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) but were unable to restore their names as the software did not provide a rollback option.

Separately, EC officials also rejected questions over the legality of an additional declaration sought from new voters along with Form 6 during the SIR. Citing official documents, they said the declaration requirement was part of the June 24, 2025 Bihar SIR order and had the unanimous approval of the Commission.

The same provision was included in subsequent SIR orders covering 12 states and Union Territories in October 2025, and 19 states and UTs in

May 2026, again with unanimous approval.

The officials maintained that Form 6 itself was not amended and that an additional declaration was sought along with it. The EC officials also cited a May 27 Supreme Court judgment which held that the SIR exercise did not conflict with the Representation of the People Act or the 1960 Rules and was traceable to Section 21(3) of the Act read with Article 324 of the Constitution.

Son prime suspect in murder of Kanpur businessman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kanpur

On the evening of 5 September, Vineet Manocha, 60, a pharmaceutical trader who ran a business on Birhana Road with his son, was stabbed to death in his apartment at Ratan Orbit in Kalyanpur. At first, it seemed like a sudden, violent attack. However, after several days of investigation, police now believe it was a family conspiracy involving debt, suspicion, and fear of losing property.

According to police, the victim's son, Subrat Manocha, built up over ₹40 lakh in debts from gambling and IPL betting. His father gave him about ₹40,000 each month for expenses, but Subrat was paying around ₹55,000 every month toward loan repayments. Investigators also believe Subrat feared his father might start living with another woman and transfer property to her.

Police say that financial pressure and worries about inheritance led Subrat to plan his father's death. At first, he wanted it to look like an acci-



dent or natural causes, but the plan changed. The attack happened on 5 September inside the family's apartment. The next day, police arrested Subrat's wife, Shalu Manocha, and two alleged contract killers, Vishal and Rajkishore. Subrat was still a suspect. On 23 September, police arrested him and brought him to court the next day, where they sent him to judicial custody.

Commissioner of Police, Kanpur, Raghubir Lal said the conspiracy came to light through call records, CCTV footage, digital and scientific evidence, and other clues. Investigators found deleted chats between Subrat and

Vishal. Their locations matched several times before the murder. A few days earlier, Vishal got a new SIM card, and his first call from it was to Subrat's father, and he promised ₹6 lakh.

Lal further alleged that Subrat instructed him to name Shalu if he was caught. Police are checking those claims against call records and other material. Recoveries added physical weight to the digital trail. Vishal was taken back to Ratan Orbit, where he indicated he had thrown a key while fleeing; police recovered it from an empty plot adjoining the complex.

Police took Rajkishore to

Kanpur Central railway station, where they found his blood-stained trousers and a black scarf behind a public toilet, as he showed them. During questioning, Shalu broke down and told police she was implicated to protect her husband.

Investigators believe Subrat and Vishal tried to shift suspicion onto her. Commissioner Lal said there is not enough evidence yet to prove Shalu's involvement.

She has not been cleared, but if a full review of all evidence does not show her role, police may submit a report to the court.

Police prepared over 100 questions about movements, phone calls, financial transactions, and connections. They questioned the suspects several times on the night of 23 September. After a medical check around 11 am on 24 September, police sent Shalu, Vishal, and Rajkishore back to jail when their 24-hour custody ended at noon. The investigation is still ongoing. Lal stressed that they will check every piece of evidence independently before reaching to a conclusion.

111 MPs, MLAs switched parties after election, Nagaland tops list: ADR report

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

Making an apparent mockery of the anti-defection law, 111 sitting MPs/MLAs changed parties after being elected to the current Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha and State Assemblies. Among them, 26 were Lok Sabha MPs, seven were Rajya Sabha MPs, and 78 were MLAs.

The report of Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR) report said defection cases were reported in 17 states and union territories. Nagaland topped the list, with 32 representatives switching parties. This was followed by West Bengal with 20, Telangana with nine, Goa and Punjab with eight each, Maharashtra and Meghalaya with six each, and Manipur with five.

Interestingly, Nagaland and West Bengal alone accounted for approximately 47 percent of the total defection cases. This huge political exodus between 2022 and 2026 has changed the picture of power and



opposition in many states including Nagaland, West Bengal, Telangana, Goa, Maharashtra and Manipur.

The report shows the NDDP suffered the most losses. 25 elected representatives of this party left the party, which is 23 percent of the total defections. This was followed by 20 leaders of AITC and 19 of INC. Apart from this, 9

representatives of BRS, 7 each from AAP and NCP, 6 from Shiv Sena (UBT), 5 from JD(U) and 4 from NPP also changed their parties. The most shocking thing is that the number of leaders coming from NDDP, AITC and Congress was 64, which is 58 percent of the total defection cases.

The NPF was the primary choice for party-changers,

with 32 leaders joining the party. This was followed by the BJP with 29 and the Nationalist Citizens Party of India with 20. The Congress received nine, the Shiv Sena eight, the NPP six, and the PPA four. The report indicates that the NPF, BJP, and Nationalist Citizens Party of India together attracted 81 out of 111 leaders. This repre-

sents 73 percent of the total defections.

In its report, ADR stated that in recent years, defection by MLAs has been a significant factor in the collapse of governments or political changes in some states. Nagaland saw the highest number of defections, with 32 representatives changing sides, creating a new balance of political forces there. In West Bengal, the departure of 20 MPs from the AITC altered the direction of opposition politics. In Telangana, nine BRS MLAs joined the Congress, weakening the party's strength in the Assembly and strengthening its position. In Goa, eight Congress MLAs joined the BJP. In Manipur, five JD(U) MLAs joined the BJP, while in Maharashtra, six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs joined the Shinde faction's Shiv Sena. The report concludes that in many states, defection altered the political landscape created by voters at the time of the election.

Minister's daughter killed in road accident in Jamshedpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

Four people, including Trisha Singh, daughter of Jharkhand Rural Development and Panchayati Raj Minister Deepika Pandey Singh, were killed early Thursday when their car rammed into a stationary truck on Marine Drive Road in Jamshedpur.

The accident took place around 2 to 3 am near Domuhani in the Sonari police station area.

A white Maruti Swift, carrying two men and two women, was travelling on the four-lane highway when it collided with the back of a truck that had broken down the previous night. Police said the vehicle had been stranded since around 10 pm on Wednesday and was parked on the right side of the road near the divider.

Although a branch from a leafy tree had been placed behind the truck as a warning, no proper reflectors or hazard lights were visible.

The crash flattened the front of the car and pushed it under the truck. When the rescue teams arrived, they discovered that all four



People gather at the site after a car rammed into a stationary truck in Jamshedpur on Thursday. Jharkhand minister Dipika Pandey Singh's daughter was among four people killed in the incident

people inside were trapped in the wreckage.

Using a gas cutter, the bodies were removed once the broken car had been cut open. Deputy Superintendent of Police Manoj Thakur stated that the four individuals had died immediately. The victims were identified as Trisha Singh, Sarthak Agarwal, Naman Gupta and Vanshika Khandelwal, all of whom lived in Sonari. Police said the four were young students travelling together. The bodies were then sent to the MGM Medical College Hospital for post-

mortem examination.

Sanjay Suman, who is in charge of the Sonari police station, said police have launched an investigation to determine how the car hit the stationary truck and whether the broken-down vehicle was properly marked.

They observed that the lack of clear markings on the dark section of the highway might have contributed to the accident. The Chief Minister, Hemant Soren, called the deaths very distressing and stated that the sorrow of losing a child is intolerable for any parent. The Governor, Santosh

Kumar Gangwar, described the news as heart-breaking as well, and the Health Minister, Irfan Ansari, and other officials expressed their condolences to the families who have suffered the loss.

The incident has once again highlighted the risks of leaving disabled vehicles on motorways at night without adequate lighting or signage.

Police said they would take further legal action following the investigation, but for the families of the four young victims, the sorrow caused by the tragedy will be hard to forget.

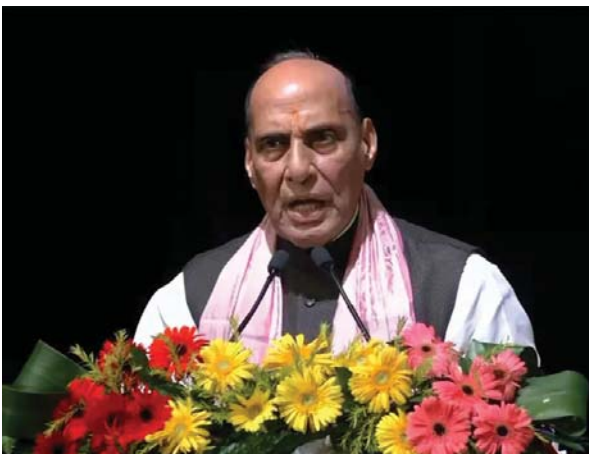
India has balance of diplomatic and military abilities: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Emphasising that a balance between diplomacy and military capabilities is necessary for the country, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday said India possesses "power of argument" as well as "argument of power", and it will accordingly use the language which the other side understands.

In his address at a defence conclave here, he also said "soft power can be a complement to hard power", but it cannot be its alternative in any way. Singh said, in India's tradition, the ideas of power and peace have not been at variance with each other. However, the "problem" started when, after Independence, a few leaders who were leading the nation, instead of taking the two thoughts together, "treated power ('shakti') and morality ('naitikta') as alternatives to each other," he argued.

In the early 1960s, then prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru himself had "acknowledged that we were out of touch with reality, and were living in an artificial atmos-



phere created by themselves only", he claimed.

"Later, many other leaders leading the country did not learn from this, and did not make any change in strategy. In our security and defence policy, a kind of 'false consensus effect' was seen," the defence minister alleged, without naming anyone.

This means, some people, who were leading India for a long time, had assumed that "akin to India, others too were in favour of peace," he said at 'DefCon' organised by News 18 network. But, under Prime Minister Narendra

Modi's leadership, there has been a "big change" in that mindset, Singh asserted.

"We have made it clear that we possess the power of argument as well as the argument of power. We will accordingly use the language which one (the other side) understands," he added.

"And, today, through diplomacy, we are working to foster peace around the world. And, we are also preparing our defence and strategic capabilities to deal with any possible threat.

"We are proponents of resolution through democra-



she can be heard objecting and asking to be released. Samastipur Superintendent of Police Arvind Pratap Singh said officers found the clip while monitoring social media on Wednesday night.

Officers identified the location as the Budhi Gandak dam bypass road and acted quickly. Police filed an FIR at Karpurigram police station under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, and the Information Technology Act. Police said the girl in the video appears to be a minor and could not be

immediately identified, so the case was taken up suo motu.

Police arrested the four accused, Vikas Kumar Sharma, Rahul Kumar, Awadhesh Paswan and Rambabu Sahni, within hours. Three are residents of Jagatsinghpur; the fourth is from nearby Bijolia. Police also seized a mobile phone used to record and share the video.

Police later said questioning suggested the incident happened about a week earlier, likely around 15 September, even though the video appeared only on 23 September.



Krishna was the centre of attraction at the event. Born in Bandhavgarh in October 2025, Krishna was named by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav during his visit to the reserve on December 31, 2025. The young elephant attracted visitors with its playful movements and activities.

Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve currently has 15 camp elephants. Of these, four are deployed for rescue operations, two for monitoring activities and nine have been included in the rejuvenation camp.

Assistant Director, Dhamokhar, Mitendra Chichkhede, explained the responsibilities and role of the camp elephants, while Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve Deputy Director Yohan Katara briefed participants about the objectives and activities planned during the camp.

Katara said the camp was intended not only to provide rest and health-care to the elephants but also to strengthen awareness about their role in wildlife management.

The event near Parasi

Gate is also aimed at promoting tourism in the buffer zone and encouraging local residents to participate in conservation activities.

Umaria Collector Rakhi Sahay, who attended the programme as chief guest, described the elephant festival as a special experience. DFO Vivek Singh, Corporation Divisional Manager Amit Patoudi, Zila Panchayat CEO Abhay Singh Ohriya and other forest officials, local representatives and residents were present.

Meanwhile, Bandhavgarh team was engaged in an elephant rescue operation in the Gorsari forest area of the Maihar forest division during the camp.

Camp elephants, wildlife health officer Dr Tomar and the rescue team participated in the operation.

Officials said this demonstrated that the elephants are used not only for routine monitoring and management but also for rescue and wildlife management operations when required.

■ States Focus



■ ACTOR MUSHTAQ KHAN DIES AFTER BATTLE WITH CANCER

Actor Mushtaq Khan, known for his character roles in over 500 films including hits such as “Welcome”, “Gadar” and “Hum Hai Rahi Pyaar Ke”, has died after a battle with cancer, son Mohsin said. Khan was admitted to Nanavati Hospital in suburban Mumbai about a fortnight ago. “He passed away due to cancer at Nanavati Hospital at around 7 pm. He had complained of stomach pain, so we took him to the hospital where doctors discovered that he had cancer. His health worsened in the last few days,” his son Mohsin told PTL. “He was perfectly fine; he had no major issues. Rather, he was shooting for the debut film of Shera’s (Salman Khan’s bodyguard) son prior to his hospitalisation,” he said. (PTI)

BANNED OUTFIT UKNA CHIEF ARRESTED IN MIZORAM

Security forces on Thursday arrested the chief of the banned Manipur-based militant outfit, United Kuki National Army (UKNA), in the Mizoram Capital, a senior police officer said. Thangkhomang Haokip, stated to be the commander-in-chief of the UKNA, has been accused of being involved in several crimes in Manipur. Aizawl Superintendent of Police Zosangliana said that Haokip was arrested during an operation by a joint team of Assam Rifles and Subsidiary Intelligence Bureau (SIB). An official of a central intelligence agency said that a search is underway for other cadres of the banned militant group, who are reportedly currently hiding in Aizawl. The UKNA is not a signatory to the Suspension of Operations (SoO) pact signed among the Centre, Manipur Government and several Kuki and Zomi militant groups, officials in Imphal said. (PTI)



CBI arrest of Abhishek Kumar marks fresh breakthrough in Mahadev betting app probe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) arrested Abhishek Kumar, considered one of the main suspects in the Mahadev Online Betting App case, right after he arrived from Dubai at Rajiv Gandhi International Airport in Hyderabad on 24 September 2026. This arrest marks a major step forward in a long-running investigation into what authorities call one of India’s biggest illegal online betting groups. Investigators believe Kumar was actively involved in running betting and gambling operations for Mahadev Book. He is accused of coordinating betting panels, collecting money for the network, and helping buy property in Dubai with money from illegal gambling.

Right after his arrest, a search turned up evidence that the CBI says shows Kumar worked closely with the main accused, Saurabh Chandrakar and Shubham Soni. After his arrest, police brought Kumar before a local court in Hyderabad, which gave them three days to transfer him. Police then took him to Raipur, where another court ordered two more days of custody for further questioning. The case itself has a long history. Mahadev Online Book. This case has been going on for years. Mahadev Online Book started around 2018 and was reportedly set up by Saurabh Chandrakar, who used to sell juice in Bhilai, and his associate Ravi Uppal, both from Chhattisgarh. They ran most operations from Dubai and



built a franchise-like network of branches, called panels, across India. Panel operators kept part of the profits, while the main promoters managed the platforms, user accounts, payments, and overseas transfers. They also ran Telegram groups and offered betting on cricket, other sports and casino-style games via linked platforms such as Skyexchange, Tiger Exchange, Gold365 and Laser247. Enforcement Directorate (ED) findings have placed the scale of alleged proceeds of crime in the tens of thousands of crores over several years, with thousands of active panels at peak. The money was reportedly moved through fake bank accounts, hawala networks, and foreign companies before being invested in luxury properties in Dubai, such as expensive apartments and villas. Some of the money was also said to be paid as protection money to public officials. The Chhattisgarh government handed over 13 police cases from different stations in the state to the CBI. So far, the agency has filed eight

■ States reaffirm resolve to implement Narcotics Vision Document 2026-29

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

States and Union Territories have renewed their commitment to the Vision Document on Narcotics Control (2026-29), aiming to step up efforts against drug trafficking. The two-day conference, themed “United Resolve, Shared Responsibility,” began on 22 September 2026 with an inauguration by Union Home and Cooperation Minister Amit Shah. The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) organised the event, which brought together ANTF leaders from 36 States and UTs, along with officials from various government departments.

During his opening speech, Shah said narcotics are a serious threat to the country and set a goal to eliminate the drug trade in India by 31 December 2029. He explained that a Drug-Free India is important for building a developed nation by 2047 and protecting future generations. Shah admitted that reaching the 2029 goal will be difficult, but believes it is possible if Central and State Governments work together. The conference featured three technical sessions that discussed how to meet the Vision Document targets over the next three years. Topics included demand reduction, prevention and rehabilitation in controlling narcotics. Senior officials from key ministries introduced the UGC’s “Nasha Mukta Campus Framework” for Drug-Free Higher Educational Institutions, the creation of 500-metre Drug-Free Zones around schools and colleges, the expansion of the Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyan, and national programs to improve de-addiction centres and their outreach. On the second day, the conference focused on improving coordination in narcotics cases with INTERPOL and foreign agencies.



en State ANTFs, make NCORD and JCC meetings more results-focused, move from focusing only on seizures to targeting entire networks, use financial profiling, apply the PITNDPS Act effectively, and focus on prosecuting key figures and organised trafficking groups. One session highlighted the importance of demand reduction, prevention, and rehabilitation in controlling narcotics. Senior officials from key ministries introduced the UGC’s “Nasha Mukta Campus Framework” for Drug-Free Higher Educational Institutions, the creation of 500-metre Drug-Free Zones around schools and colleges, the expansion of the Nasha Mukta Bharat Abhiyan, and national programs to improve de-addiction centres and their outreach. On the second day, the conference focused on improving coordination in narcotics cases with INTERPOL and foreign agencies.

Topics included working with international partners, deporting fugitives, the role of FIU-IND in financial investigations, and using the PITNDPS Act. Participants also discussed how digital databases like NIDAAN, e-Sakshya, e-Prison, and CCTNS can help enforcement, as well as the use of Nar-K9 dogs for intelligence-led operations, analysis of synthetic drugs, and the MAC platform. Another session addressed challenges with precursors, synthetic drugs, and hidden laboratories, along with ways to tackle these issues. The discussion included how the chemical industry can help prevent the diversion of precursor chemicals for making synthetic drugs and how to spot signs of illegal labs. The session also covered best practices for destroying illegal crops and encouraging alternative farming. The conference looked at new trends in drug crimes involving the darknet and cryptocurrencies, as well as tools for investigating these cases.

Participants shared best practices from different States to fight drug trafficking, such as using technology, working together across agencies, and involving the community. In his closing speech, the DG, NCB exhorted all ANTFs and participants to stay committed to drug control efforts over the next three years. He asked States to create their own three-year drug control plans, considering their unique challenges and ensuring they align with the National Vision Document on Narcotics Control (2026-2029). Shah repeated that it is time to shift from focusing only on seizures to targeting entire drug networks to meet new challenges in drug trafficking. He stressed that enforcement and intelligence agencies need to work together, share information, and coordinate to find and break up drug networks at all levels.

Argentina to roll out easier travel, work rules for Indians

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Argentina is rolling out easier travel and work rules for Indians and wants New Delhi to match the opening, Ambassador Mariano Caucino said Wednesday at the Iconic Tourism Summit. Speaking in the capital, Caucino said Buenos Aires is pursuing a deliberate policy to draw more Indian visitors. “Since August 2025, Indians holding a valid US visa can visit Argentina as tourists for up to 90 days without an Argentine visa. And that is not all. Indian nationals can also get a five-year business visa, free of charge,” he said. The ambassador framed tourism as part of a broader strategic partnership. “The driving force is strategic. India is our partner on first-order challenges like energy security and food security. Bringing our peoples closer through tourism can only strengthen that partnership. The direction is clear: fewer barriers, more contact between our peoples. We would welcome reciprocity from India, so that Argentines can travel to India just as easily.” Aviation talks are under way. “Our civil aviation authorities are negotiating

an Air Services Agreement. It will give airlines from both countries more freedom to fly between us and allow tools such as code-share agreements,” Caucino said. He added that the effort fits a wider Argentine push: “This is part of a clear policy of the Argentine Government. Since taking office, it has signed agreements with more than 55 countries to open up our air transport market.” More airline freedom, he argued, would mean more routes, more competition and better fares. “Distance is real, but real progress can be made.” Asked about tighter borders in parts of the Global North, the envoy said migration and border policy remain sovereign choices. “We respect the decisions of every country, while Argentina’s message is openness to tourism and investment. We want Indians to visit, do business and invest.” Caucino also pointed to India’s young tech workforce and Argentina’s existing digital nomad visa, which allows remote workers employed by foreign firms to live in Argentina for up to six months, renewable for another six.

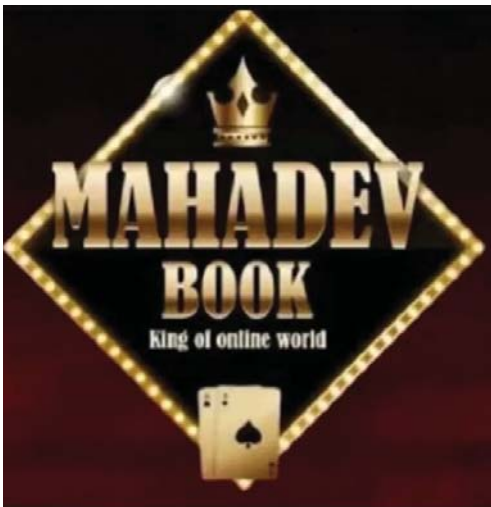


Mahadev betting app still active, ED tells court

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) told a special PMLA court in Raipur that the Mahadev online betting app and related websites generated about ₹94,400 crore in illegal earnings over the past 10 years. In its sixth prosecution complaint, filed recently, the ED named 42 people and companies as accused and said the main platform is still active, running many panels.

The case started in October 2022 after the ED reviewed police FIRs from Chhattisgarh, Andhra Pradesh, and West Bengal. So far, the agency has named 116 accused in six chargesheets, arrested 14 people, and searched around 190 locations. Separate CBI investigations have called this network one of the biggest illegal betting syndicates found in India. Investigators identified two men from Bhilai, Chhattisgarh, Saurabh Chandrakar, a former juice shop owner, and Ravi Uppal, as the main promoters. They started Mahadev Online Book around 2018 and later operated it from Dubai. Both are still on the run. Interpol has issued Red Corner Notices, and proceedings for fugitive economic offenders have begun. Chandrakar was later reported in Oman, and extradition efforts are



ongoing. Both men deny founding or promoting the app. Mahadev was not just one site but a group of illegal betting websites hosted overseas. Related platforms include Skyexchange.com, which the ED links to Dubai-based Hari Shankar Tibrewal and has operated since 2016, as well as Lotus365, Reddy Anna, FairPlay, Laser247, Tiger Exchange, and Gold365. The latest complaint says Mahadev alone generated ₹75,000 to 80,000 crore since 2019, Skyexchange made ₹11,000 to 12,000 crore, and Lotus365 about ₹2,400 crore. The syndicate used a franchise panel model. Local operators across India found customers, created IDs, collected deposits, and ran bets on sports and games like cricket, football, tennis, badminton, poker, teen patti, and other games of chance. Promoters reportedly kept 70 to 75 per cent of the profits. They advertised through private WhatsApp, Telegram, and Facebook groups, promising quick money. Users got different numbers for deposits and withdrawals. Investigators say the games were set up to make customers lose money over time. Earlier estimates said 2,000 to 3,200 active panels generated about ₹11,400 crore each year. The money moved through thousands of mule bank accounts opened with other people’s KYC documents, and then through hawala, cryptocurrency, and shell companies. The funds were used to buy luxury property in Dubai, including assets



linked to the Burj Khalifa, and were also invested in Indian equity markets through foreign portfolio investments. The latest chargesheet names high-profile people like EBIX chairman Vikas Garg, who was arrested in July 2026 after authorities seized assets worth about ₹940.77 crore, and EaseMyTrip co-founder Nishant Pitti, whose demat shares worth ₹59.60 crore were attached. The ED claims Pitti helped move betting money into the stock market and was close to SkyExchange’s alleged owner. Pitti has said he did not know about the chargesheet. Total assets attached during the investigation have ranged from about ₹1,885 crore to over ₹4,300 crore at different times. The ED has claimed that the racket had support

from local police and politicians in Chhattisgarh, and that bureaucrats and politically connected people received illegal payments. The CBI has filed related corruption chargesheets. Despite years of raids, the agency told the court that the Mahadev platform is still active. Mirror sites, changing domains, and encrypted groups have helped the franchise network survive. A huge gap remains between the estimated illegal earnings and the assets recovered. The main question now is whether the Raipur court proceedings, more asset attachments, and extradition efforts can close that gap, or if the panels will keep operating. This remains at the heart of one of India’s biggest illegal betting investigations, sources in the ED said on Thursday.

Leh shuts down on September 24 violence anniversary; Wangchuk seeks probe report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Leh witnessed a complete shut-down on Thursday as part of “Shaheed Diwas” (Martyrs’ Day) to remember the sacrifices of four people who were killed during the violence on September 24, 2025, over demands for statehood and Sixth Schedule safeguards. A prayer meeting was also organised by the Ladakh Buddhist Association (LBA) at NDS stadium, Leh, to pay homage to the victims. Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk, Chering Dorjay Lakrook, Member of Parliament, Mohammed Hanifa Jan, Thupstan Chhewang, Asghar Karbalai, and Sajjad Kargili, among others, addressed the gathering.

Addressing the gathering after attending the prayer meeting, Wangchuk demanded that the findings of the judicial inquiry into last year’s deadly violence in Leh be made public, saying, “Justice must be served to Ladakh.” “The truth is being suppressed and hasn’t been revealed even after a year. The impression people here have is that there were attempts to incite Buddhist-Muslim communal riots long before this, and they have been happening. In that same sequence, three Muslims were appointed as magistrates to ensure a firing order was written, so that it could be blamed on Buddhists—that ‘they’ let people die. But look at their character; they refused. There was no need



for such firing—to shoot people in the chest and do such things. All this will become clear when the inquiry commission’s report comes out. They must release

it.” There should be an investigation. If you do not release the inquiry commission report, we will demand the creation of a People’s Tribunal.



We will appeal to those in our country’s justice system whose conscience is still alive, to those judges, retired judges and all institutions to form a People’s

Tribunal, ask the people, and give your own judgement if this continues to be suppressed. We still hope that the government will provide justice to these martyrs and to Ladakh, which has saved the Nation’s borders with such patriotism. Justice must be served to the martyrs. Justice must be served to Ladakh, he added. During the day, several markets and business hubs in Leh and Kargil remained closed, while traffic was thin on the roads, disrupting normal life. During the prayer meeting, the leaders, in their addresses, accused the Ladakh Police of installing barricades, specifically to stop the general public from attending the prayer meet.

The Ladakh Police later refuted these allegations. “It is hereby clarified that the police did not stop any individual from proceeding to the venue or attending the event. Any security deployments or barricades in the wider city area were strictly part of standard traffic and crowd-management protocols, established solely because the organisers had officially projected a large gathering. The claims made by the leaders regarding police obstruction are totally false, baseless, and misleading. Earlier, on Wednesday, Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena approved the withdrawal of criminal cases against 20 people, who were booked in connection with the violence.



Editor's
TAKE

Seafarers are not collateral damage

This World Maritime Day, let us spare a thought for India's 300,000-strong seafaring workforce, increasingly caught in wars and piracy they had no part in starting

This year's World Maritime Day theme is "From Policy to Practice: Powering Maritime Excellence", which sounds bureaucratic. Every year, the day reminds us that ships carry more than 80 per cent of world trade. For India, this year's theme is a stark indictment. The distance between rules on paper and safety at sea is now being measured in coffins.

India supplies more than 300,000 seafarers to the global merchant fleet: engine-room fitters, cadets and chief engineers whose wages sustain entire villages. Since the war on Iran began, at least ten Indian sailors have been killed and dozens injured around the Strait of Hormuz, in attacks by both American and Iranian forces. Three died aboard MT Settebello in June; among them was an engine fitter, six months into his first voyage, the sole earner for his family. This week, another Indian was killed when a bulk carrier was struck in the Strait of Hormuz. Meanwhile, piracy has returned to the Horn of Africa. In August, two hijacked vessels carried 22 Indian crew.

The tragedy is how familiar this has become. Seafarers are hired through recruitment agencies, placed on flag-of-convenience ships, sometimes on tankers accused of sanctions-busting, and left in a legal grey zone when missiles arrive. Families speak of no warning, no compensation and no answers.

The international community must begin with first principles. Merchant ships are civilian objects under humanitarian law, not bargaining chips in a blockade. Belligerents must give warning, allow engine rooms to be evacuated, and prefer boarding to missiles. The IMO and the UN should create an independent mechanism to investigate attacks on seafarers, because impunity guarantees repetition.

On piracy, naval patrols must be coordinated and sustained, but lasting security also requires giving Somalia's coastal communities an alternative to the ransom economy. And "policy to practice" must mean that flag states enforce the Maritime Labour Convention's guarantees on repatriation, abandonment and compensation. India has begun to act. It has announced a real-time dashboard to track Indian crew in the Gulf and advised shipping companies against hiring new Indian seafarers for Hormuz voyages. But shifting liability onto employers is not a strategy. New Delhi should blacklist recruitment agencies that place crew on risky or shadow-fleet vessels, make war-risk insurance and prompt death compensation mandatory, and set up a permanent crisis cell with evacuation protocols.

The Navy's escort and rescue role in the Arabian Sea should be expanded and formalised. Above all, India must use its weight as one of the world's largest suppliers of seafarers, and its standing with both Washington and Tehran, to demand safe passage and accountability in plain language, not muted statements.

There is also a structural case. Too much of India's seafaring workforce sails on foreign flags with little bargaining power. More Indian-flagged tonnage, stronger training and a seafarer welfare fund would give crews real options and leverage.

On this Maritime Day, the pledge should be simple: no Indian sailor should ever die for someone else's war.

BRICS: From declarations to delivery

The Delhi BRICS summit has given India a larger role in shaping the Global South's agenda. The real test now is whether New Delhi can turn the summit's broad commitments on trade, investment, technology and global governance into concrete action and use BRICS to advance a more representative multipolar order



KALYANI SHANKAR

Following last week's significant BRICS summit in Delhi, what are the next steps? The summit produced several recommendations that could help advance the BRICS agenda. It has positioned India to play a proactive role in shaping global governance, and the Modi government is likely to seize these opportunities to advocate for a multipolar world that includes emerging economies in decision-making.

The summit took place amid significant conflict in West Asia and the ongoing war between Russia and Ukraine. Trade and supply chains have been disrupted due to strained relations among key global players, with the US using trade and tariffs as tools.

During this important time, leaders from China (Xi Jinping), Russia (Vladimir Putin), Iran, Abu Dhabi's Crown Prince, and the presidents of Vietnam and the Philippines met. The summit showed that countries with different interests can come together around a common goal that helps the Global South, even amid regional rivalries. This meeting occurred while there was significant conflict in West Asia and an ongoing war between Russia and Ukraine.

One of Modi's most immediate priorities will be to strengthen trade agreements and economic partnerships with other BRICS nations - Brazil, Russia, China and South Africa - while also exploring partnerships with other emerging economies. By fostering closer ties with these countries, India aims to diversify its trade relationships beyond traditional Western markets.

For India, ensuring an uninterrupted flow of foreign investment, especially in technology, manufacturing and sustainable energy, will be critical to stimulating economic growth. Although India has come a long way since the 1991 foreign exchange crisis, it still needs foreign investment.

Recognising startups' role in driving economic change, Modi's administration aims to implement measures to build a robust entrepreneurial ecosystem. This may include simplifying regulations that hinder business development, offering financial incentives such as grants and subsidies, and establishing innovation hubs across the country. These initiatives aim not only to attract domestic and foreign investors but also to encourage homegrown talent to innovate, thereby creating jobs and stimulating local economies.

Modi might introduce a suite of structural reforms across sectors to improve India's ease



IF INDIA WANTS TO REMAIN ONE OF THE WORLD'S FASTEST-GROWING ECONOMIES OVER THE NEXT TWENTY YEARS AND BECOME A LEADER IN THE GLOBAL SOUTH, IT MUST ENGAGE ACTIVELY WITH BRICS

The writer is a popular columnist

of doing business. These reforms could focus on regulatory reforms.

Enhancing infrastructure through increased public and private investment will be crucial. Improved roads, ports and digital infrastructure will support business operations and attract foreign investment.

With a focused approach to technology, renewable energy and sustainable practices, the government can offer incentives to attract investment. This may include tax breaks for green energy projects or support for technological advances across industries.

As climate change remains a major concern, Modi is likely to place significant emphasis on renewable energy initiatives after the summit. By committing to ambitious renewable energy targets, New Delhi aims high.

These initiatives may include investments in solar, wind and other green technologies; fostering partnerships with other nations to drive innovation; and sharing technological advancements that can benefit developing countries in the Global South.

During the BRICS summit, a spotlight was shone on the issues faced by emerging economies, particularly those in the Global South. Modi is expected to strengthen India's advocacy for policies that address climate change, poverty alleviation and sustainable development. By rallying support from fellow BRICS countries and other emerging economies, India can work to create frameworks that promote collaboration on these challenges.

Alongside economic strategies, enhancing regional security will remain a key focus for Modi. Strengthening ties and security partner-

ships with neighbouring countries will be pivotal for ensuring stability in the region. This could include increased intelligence sharing, joint military exercises and collaborative efforts to combat cross-border terrorism. Strengthening regional ties will not only raise India's global profile but also foster trust and collaboration among neighbouring nations, aligning their collective interests.

India's active participation in international forums will also be a priority. After the BRICS summit, Modi may engage in discussions at various multilateral platforms.

As India prepares for Assembly elections, it may take steps to reassure voters that their economic futures are secure. By highlighting investments in education, health infrastructure and social welfare programmes, Modi can appeal to a broad demographic. His government may also promote policies centred around green technology and environmental sustainability, showcasing a commitment to future generations.

Prime Minister Modi's steps after the BRICS summit will be multifaceted and strategically aligned with India's long-term goals. By prioritising economic revitalisation, fostering innovation, strengthening regional cooperation and advocating for the Global South, India can strengthen its role as a vital player on the global stage. The coming months will be critical as Modi's administration lays the groundwork for a more prosperous and influential India in a rapidly evolving multipolar world.

If India wants to remain one of the world's fastest-growing economies over the next twenty years and become a leader in the Global South, it must engage actively with BRICS.

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

Feed People, Love People, Remember God

Some teachings arrive not through scripture, but through a life lived simply in front of us.

Neem Karoli Baba, revered across India and known widely through devotees like Ram Dass and Steve Jobs, rarely offered long discourses. When asked how to live rightly, his answer stayed remarkably consistent: feed people, serve people, love everyone and remember God.

He lived this instruction visibly, ensuring that no one who visited his Ashram, regardless of status or background, ever left without being fed, seated and treated with equal warmth.

His teachings resisted complexity deliberately. He seemed to suggest that most spiritual confusion dissolves the moment we simply act with generosity and love toward whoever is in front of us, rather than searching endlessly for more elaborate answers.

We often complicate our spiritual seeking, chasing techniques, retreats and philosophies, while overlooking the ordinary person beside us who could use a meal, a kind word, or simple attention.

Today, feed someone, literally or figuratively, serve one person without expecting anything back, and let that simple act be your practice, rather than waiting for a more profound spiritual insight to arrive first.

-DAIV

Our fascination with the extremes



SANJAY CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

I recently met a senior from my society during the morning walk. He had celebrated his eighty-seventh birthday with his family, who had prepared a PowerPoint presentation with photographs capturing his journey from childhood to the present. Half-jokingly, he said he was thinking of burying the document somewhere in the society lawns for a future generation to discover. A time capsule of sorts.

It was not long before our conversation turned to the extreme positions, and often the language, adopted by some of our esteemed residents on the WhatsApp groups while criticising the incumbent governing body. We have witnessed this for the past ten years and will probably continue to do so, irrespective of who occupies those positions. We had a hearty laugh when we realised that

someone would probably have an objection even to his idea of burying the time capsule.

I continued with my walk, still thinking about our fondness for extreme positions, when a rather more literal version of the same thought presented itself. I soon came across a few delivery boys whizzing breezily past on their e-bikes. Some of them appeared barely old enough to possess a driving licence. The absolute chutzpah with which they negotiate the society roads has to be seen to be believed. It is not only these youngsters. Many older residents also seem to think little about the well-being of pedestrians sharing those roads.

But there is one thing I have frequently noticed on our roads. When approaching a bend, riders and drivers often swing towards the extreme right or left, sometimes straying onto the wrong side of the road. During my travels in Europe, I have often noticed the opposite - the discipline of staying on the appropriate side while negotiating a bend. As I walked, the words left, right and extreme stayed with me.

Extreme positions are visible in corporate boardrooms too. Juniors learn quite early in their careers that supporting the strongly held position of a powerful senior can sometimes be more advantageous than questioning it. Seniors, in turn, can become so entrenched in their views that adopting a middle path becomes difficult, even when it may eventually produce a better outcome. Business owners sometimes continue pursuing an idea long after the writing on the wall has become visible to

almost everyone else.

The problem with an extreme position is not necessarily that it is wrong. Sometimes circumstances demand one. The problem begins when the position becomes more important than the purpose for which it was taken. A residential WhatsApp discussion is meant to improve the community in which we live. A road is meant to allow everyone to reach somewhere safely. A boardroom discussion should eventually help the business make a better decision. Yet, somewhere along the way, winning the argument can become more important than achieving the objective.

For much of my life, I associated left, right and centre primarily with politics. How naive I was. Apparently, left and right extend far beyond politics.

Life around us seems determined to make us choose sides. WhatsApp groups do it. Boardrooms do it. Social media certainly does it. Sometimes even a bend in the road appears to demand that we choose an extreme. But must we?

Perhaps the middle is not always an unwilling compromise between two strongly held positions. Sometimes it may simply be the space from where we can see both sides clearly enough to decide where we actually need to go.

The writer is founder of Kala - Crazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

IITs must address student concerns

Students strain every nerve to gain admission to premier institutions such as the IITs. They enter these institutions carrying great ambitions, dreams and plans for their future, and the quality education they receive helps make them valuable citizens. Losing such students, for whatever reason, must therefore be addressed from every possible angle.

The news about authorities rearranging ceiling fans was more amusing than reassuring. A thorough study is needed to restore confidence among students and parents and bring necessary administrative improvements.

Educated unemployment, declining educational standards, commercialisation of education and students prioritising coaching centres over college attendance also require urgent attention.

The focus must remain on creating a safe, supportive and academically meaningful environment for students. Addressing these concerns sincerely and implementing necessary reforms will be essential to preventing such unpleasant incidents from recurring. The authorities must act with sensitivity, transparency and responsibility, keeping students' welfare above institutional image.

AG RAJMOHAN | ANANTAPUR

Questions over EC accountability

The latest revelations about the Election Commission of India are deeply disturbing and cannot be brushed aside as an internal disagreement. Two Election Commissioners reportedly raised objections at least 14 times over 10 months, concerning voter registration and deletion, changes to Form 6, and access to electoral databases. The ECI has maintained that all decisions, including those related to the Special Intensive Revision, were unanimous.

The Election Commission is a constitutional institution, not the personal domain of any office-holder. No individual should appear bigger than the institution they occupy. When the authority entrusted with protecting citizens' voting rights faces questions about transparency, procedure and internal accountability, every Indian has the right to demand answers.

This is not about one party or another. It is about the credibility of India's democracy. Power without transparency is dangerous. Authority without accountability is worse. Every objection must be examined, and every decision must withstand scrutiny. Every citizen must have confidence that their right to vote cannot be compromised behind closed doors. Democracy demands nothing less.

NOOPUR BARUAH | TEZPUR

Trump's diplomatic calculus: Xi and Modi

Breaking with standard protocol to meet Chinese President Xi Jinping, Donald Trump's decision to welcome him at Joint Base Andrews, with First Lady Melania Trump, a 100-foot red carpet, an honour guard and a military ceremony, was an intentional display of diplomatic respect. By contrast, Trump has frequently emphasised his personal friendship with Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who has typically been received with large public rallies and formal White House meetings. Trump has also characterised this dynamic as "tough love", balancing public camaraderie with transactional, America-first trade policies, including tariffs on Indian imports.

Under these circumstances, Trump's decision to greet Xi at Joint Base Andrews rather than at the executive residence underscores the high-stakes nature of US-China relations. It highlights how the US administration uses prestige and grand protocol to manage a major global competitor, while employing public affection and economic pressure to negotiate with strategic partner India.

In brief, these distinct approaches reflect how Washington tailors its diplomatic toolkit to the geopolitical realities of two critical Asian counterparts.

BIDYUT KUMAR CHATTERJEE | FARIDABAD

PICTALK

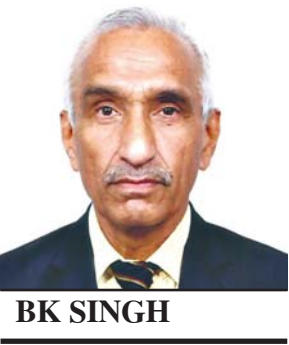


Tourists take part in river rafting activity, in the Ganga river, in Rishikesh, Dehradun district, Uttarakhand

PHOTO: PTI

BRICS Delhi Declaration: Consensus on War but no clarity on climate action

The Delhi declaration found common ground on diplomacy, terrorism and trade, but left difficult questions on climate action, deforestation and energy security unanswered. As ecological pressures mount, BRICS must move beyond declarations and develop concrete strategies to protect forests, biodiversity and vulnerable regions



BK SINGH

Like the G20 2023 Delhi Declaration, which was achieved amid the escalating Russia-Ukraine war and stated that all states should refrain from using force for territorial acquisition without specifically mentioning Russia, BRICS members at the 2026 Delhi gathering also achieved a joint communique. The joint statement prioritised dialogue and diplomacy to resolve disputes, prevent civilian casualties and damage to infrastructure, respect the sovereignty and territorial integrity of all states, and exercise maximum restraint over continued escalation. The continuing Gulf war and tensions between the UAE and Iran had cast a shadow over the joint communique, but Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi's bilateral meeting with Iranian President Pezeshkian changed the course, and it was finally achieved.

On the issue of United Nations Security Council expansion, the joint statement mentioned the support of China and Russia for the aspirations of India and Brazil to play a greater role in the UN, including the Security Council. The members reaffirmed their commitment to combating terrorism in all its forms and manifestations, including the cross-border movement of terrorists, terrorism financing and safe havens. It also condemned the Pahalgam terrorist attack. The declaration denounced unilateral sanctions and tariffs imposed in contravention of WTO rules. All members openly hit out at the Western bloc over this. The indiscriminate increase in tariffs and non-tariff measures, or protectionism in the garb of achieving environmental objectives, reduces trade, disrupts global supply chains, brings uncertainty to trade and commerce, and exacerbates existing economic disparities.

BRICS found that the EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) undermines efforts by developing countries to address the adverse effects of climate change. While recognising the need to cut greenhouse gas emissions to meet climate goals, members sought to delink the collection of CBAM taxes from imports of carbon-intensive goods, such as cement, iron and aluminium, entering the 27 EU nations. This move by the EU has previously been opposed by the grouping, which said that the unilateral measure places an additional burden on businesses in developing economies because of the embedded emissions in their products. They reiterated in the Delhi Declaration that such measures are "discriminatory, punitive and protectionist measures that are not in line with international law". The Global South should stand together and impose a carbon legacy tax on developed nations, which are responsible for warming the planet and the consequent climatic catastrophes.

Regarding climate action in response to the Paris Climate Accord, the group called for greater action from the Western bloc based on equity and the UN principle of common but differentiated responsibilities and respective capabilities, based on different national circumstances. Though four BRICS countries — Russia, the UAE, Iran and Saudi Arabia — are major global exporters of fossil fuels, the group highlighted the need to enhance energy security by maintaining an uninterrupted flow of oil and gas, including refined products.

On the conservation front, the declaration said, "We underscore the critical role of all types of forests, including boreal and tropical forests, for conserving biodiversity, water basins and soils and providing timber and non-timber forest products of high value for economic sectors, regulating hydrological cycles as well as combating desertification, land degradation and drought, and serving as vital carbon sinks..... We also welcome the adoption of BRICS principles for 'Integrated landscape-based greening and land restoration and common understanding for Wildfire preparedness and response across BRICS countries'....." Countries have failed to control wildfires; no roadmap is laid out in the declaration.

On the issue of biodiversity conservation, the declaration said, "..... We urge developed countries to provide financial resources to developing countries to improve capacity-building and transfer of technology for conservation, sustainable use and fair and equitable sharing of benefits arising from the use of biodiversity. While appreciating the efforts of our countries to preserve rare species and noting the high vulnerability of big cats, we



THE SUBSTANTIAL PORTION OF AMAZON FORESTS IS IN BRAZIL AND INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES GET FREE HAND TO OCCUPY FOREST LAND FOR SOYABEAN CULTIVATION AND RARING ANIMALS FOR MEAT. DURING COP 30 AT BELEM, BRAZIL GOVERNMENT MOVED TO CREATE FUND FOR COMPENSATING INDIGENOUS COMMUNITIES FOR ALTERNATIVE LIVELIHOOD AND PRESERVE TROPICAL FORESTS

take note of the Republic of India's initiative to create an International Big Cat Alliance and encourage BRICS countries to work together for the conservation of big cats."

The presence of indigenous communities in the boreal and Amazon regions, important lung spaces, has accelerated deforestation. Countries continue to explore oil, gas and minerals in these regions, causing damage to tree growth and melting permafrost. Scientists have concluded that the region is warming at four times the pace of the average rise in global temperature. Snow and ice formation is declining, and glaciers are melting. Snow and glaciers have the capacity to reflect 80 per cent of incident radiation and absorb only 20 per cent. In contrast, soil and water absorb 80 per cent of solar radiation and reflect only 20 per cent. The warming in the Arctic region is thus unprecedented.

The tree line between boreal forests and the Arctic region is also shifting northwards. This does not mean that the forests we lose in the south of the boreal forests through logging and industrial activities are being made up for by the shifting tree line. The gain is far too negligible compared with the loss. Wildfires also devastate the region during the summer months. BRICS nations had no plan to reverse or halt the trend.

A substantial portion of the Amazon rainforest is in Brazil, and indigenous communities have been given a free hand to occupy forest land for soybean cultivation and rearing animals for meat. During COP30 at Belém, the Brazilian Government moved to create a fund to compensate indigenous communities for alternative livelihoods and preserve tropical forests. The proposal failed to be adopted at Belém. BRICS countries are custodians of some of the world's best boreal and tropical forests; no effort is shown to have been made in the Delhi Declaration to end deforestation.

The ongoing conflict in West Asia, including the recent Houthis attacks on Saudi Arabia and Trump's refusal to respond and protect Saudi interests, has disrupted the flow of oil and gas, and Brent crude prices have already surpassed \$100 a barrel. Both the Strait of Hormuz and Bab el-Mandeb remain choked. The Indian economy, being heavily dependent on energy imports, would have grown even better but for the disruptions. BRICS countries should have announced a strategy to accelerate the transition to renewable energy. China is a leader in solar and wind technologies as well as rare-earth processing. China must come forward to assist other BRICS members and countries of the Global South in developing green energy at a faster pace. The bilateral meeting on the sidelines of the summit between Chinese President Xi Jinping and Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi has shown a great bonhomie, but the tough question remains: why is there no progress on troop disengagement from the borders in Arunachal Pradesh and Ladakh? After the Galwan incident in May 2020, the two leaders met in Kazan in October 2024 and announced certain measures to improve relations. People-to-people contact has moved ahead in terms of the resumption of flights and visits to Kailash Mansarovar, among other things, but the trade deficit between the two countries is growing. We have a world-class pharmaceutical and services sector, yet China has not opened its market. On the contrary, China's assistance to Pakistan on the battlefield during Operation Sindoor, and its construction of the world's biggest hydropower project in Tibet, where the river Yarlung Tsangpo takes a sharp U-turn before entering India, demonstrate what the writer describes as its high-handedness. Chinese hydrologists have studied and reported that all construction sites for this project are unstable. The region is seismically prone, and earthquakes have devastated it in the past.

The devastation that happened in Nepal on August 26 was something for BRICS member countries to take note of. Eleven years ago, Nepal faced an earthquake in which more than 9,000 people perished. Scientists have said that the Himalayas are warming at twice the pace at which the rest of the globe is warming. The glacier that broke off and fell vertically into the river course carried all the construction debris dumped by China and devastated the flood plains of the Trishuli River. Should China not take stock of the situation and halt the construction?

B K Singh Retired Head of Forest Force, Karnataka

US sanctions, Indian oil and the new BRICS battle



SUKHDEV SINGH

The US President, Donald Trump, has signed the "Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026", earlier passed by the US House of Representatives, thereby eliminating the legal complexities associated with relying on executive orders. This new law empowers the US President to impose sanctions against not only Russia and Iran but also to slap penalties of up to 100 per cent tariffs on countries that import more than 15 per cent of Russia's total global oil exports. Since India and China are specifically named as the top buyers of Russian oil and gas, the Act serves as a warning to them. India imports 37 per cent (a figure now estimated to reach 45 per cent) and China imports 50 per cent of the oil Russia sells globally; these imports are essential to meeting the needs of their respective populations.

Despite strong objections from India, China and Russia following the bill's passage in the US House of Representatives, and India's warning of potential negative impacts on bilateral relations and international energy markets, the US President has signed the bill into law without hesitation. The United States, having serious geopolitical differences with Russia, may legislate such laws for itself and its allies, boycotting Russian and Iranian oil, but it has no legitimacy in coercing other sovereign nations in this American pursuit with threats of tariffs on their exports to America, thereby jeopardising their trade. Other countries are free to meet the energy requirements of their populations, procuring it from the best and most cost-effective sources available.

According to the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, Government of India, between April and August 2026, crude oil imports stood at 100,669 thousand MT and LPG imports at 4,992 thousand MT.

TradeInt import data and 'Bill of Lading' databases indicate that in the early months of 2026, India sourced its crude oil imports as follows: Iraq (19.89 per cent), Russia (17.92 per cent), Saudi Arabia (16.03 per cent), UAE (11.00 per cent), New Zealand (6.95 per cent), Brazil (5.04 per cent), Angola (4.49 per cent), Nigeria (3.93 per cent), the USA (3.51 per cent), and Kuwait (2.93 per cent). However, the situation shifted during April-August 2026 due to major disruptions in shipments from Iraq, and by August 2026, total imports from Russia had risen to approximately 45 per cent. Replacing Russia, the USA presents itself as the alternative source of oil and gas.

But to India, not only is crude oil from the US costlier than that from Russia, but freight and logistics costs also rise due to the longer distance across the Atlantic compared to Russian tanker routes. Furthermore, Indian refineries are configured for Russian and Middle Eastern crude; processing American oil, which is different in quality, poses a challenge, requiring machinery adjustments/modifications. This is likely the case for China too. So, why shouldn't India import oil from Russia? Why should India forgo cheaper Russian imports in favour of costlier ones from the US? This is precisely where the shoe pinches, with India spinning "strategic autonomy" to balance between the global forces for its trade in its national interest while the US coerces it into its own policies and geopolitical designs. This is the politics of "weaponising trade" against India and China, on the one hand, and a "trade war" against Russia and Iran, on the other. An interesting aspect of this legislation is that it exempts countries that purchase less than 15 per cent of Russia's total global energy exports and are taking "significant steps" to reduce their imports from Russia. These countries include Japan, France, Belgium and other European nations that share the US policy on the Russia-Ukraine war. There is also a peculiar political dynamic in how Russian oil imports are assessed to exempt some countries: rather than assessing the percentage of Russian energy share in a country's own total energy imports, the percentage of a country's imports from Russia is assessed against Russia's total global energy exports. Interestingly, Europe collectively remains the largest global buyer of Russian LNG, accounting for nearly half (49 per cent) of Russia's worldwide shipments and contributing a significant portion of Russia's gas revenue.

The intentions of the Act raise several questions, with answers inscribed within if read between the lines. If the purpose of this American legislation is to control Russia's 'war chest', then why is there a condition of a 15 per cent threshold? In reality, the law and the US President's prior decisions are part of global geopolitics, wherein European nations largely align with American policy, particularly on Ukraine's bid for EU membership and the ensuing Russia-Ukraine war. Consequently, European countries are reducing their reliance on Russian oil and gas in accordance with their own foreign policy objectives; furthermore, geographically, Europe is much closer to the US than India or China are, resulting in significantly lower oil and gas transportation costs to them.

Thus, this legislation is clearly targeted at the BRICS nations — specifically India, China and Russia. The factors, such as Masoud Pezeshkian's presence as a full member at the BRICS summit and the contents of the BRICS declaration condemning "unilateral coercive measures", reaffirming the commitment to "multilateralism and multi-polarity", emphasising "comprehensive reform of the UN Security Council", acknowledging cross-border interoperability for payment and messaging channels, and promoting "trade settlement and investment using BRICS local currencies", accelerated the passage of the bill by a bipartisan vote and the prompt signing of it into law by the American President. The rapid push to enact the bill, legalising the tariffs in a more stringent form, the later inclusion of Iran, and naming India and China as the top tariff targets can be viewed as an attempt to dampen the geopolitical and economic momentum generated by the BRICS-2026 New Delhi Declaration.

The law serves as a weapon to directly attack the alternative economic networks that BRICS members are striving to strengthen. BRICS, being a political and trade alliance, promises to use national currencies for mutual trade, avoiding threats from the dollar, unlike a military alliance of the 'European Union' that promises its members an attack on one as an attack on all. The US President, as the strongest member of the 'European Union', has confused a 'trade alliance' with a 'military alliance'. In this confusion, he wants to bulldoze BRICS, but he may not succeed. The 11 full-member countries and 10 partner-member countries, with nearly half the population and 40 per cent of the world's GDP, constituting BRICS, can steer the world's trajectory towards the Global South and become the 'Rule Shaper', avoiding escalating "differences into disputes".

The writer is a former Professor at Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar, and former Vice-Chairman of INTACH

Let Vande Mataram rise above the politics of patriotism



SABIR NISHAT

Few songs in modern Indian history carry the emotional and political weight of Vande Mataram. Composed in the late nineteenth century, it became a battle cry of the freedom struggle and entered the national imagination long before Independence.

A hundred and fifty years on, it is back at the centre of a political storm. The Congress Working Committee has chosen to retain its 1937 position that only the first two stanzas be sung, drawing criticism from the BJP-led government, which promotes the full six-stanza composition at official functions. The row arrives in the familiar vocabulary of Indian politics: nationalism, appeasement, secularism, patriotism. Perhaps the question itself is wrong. The real issue is whether a national symbol can command respect without becoming a test of political loyalty.

Vande Mataram is more than a song by Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay. It is also a historical record. Its opening two stanzas earned their place in the freedom movement, sung at political gatherings and bound up with the anti-colonial cause. The later verses carry religious imagery, including invocations of Durga. Even before Independence, that difference mattered.

In 1937, the Congress resolved that the first two

stanzas could serve national purposes, while portions that might unsettle some of India's religious communities were set aside. From the vantage point of 2026, it is easy to dismiss this as appeasement, but that would flatten history. The leaders of that era were building a nationalism that had to accommodate vast religious, linguistic and cultural diversity. Their concern was less literary merit than making a national symbol acceptable to as many Indians as possible.

But history cannot be invoked selectively either. The Union government's push for the complete version rests on a different argument: the song should be understood as Bankim wrote it, not merely through the two stanzas once chosen for public use. That position is not unreasonable. The full composition belongs to India's literary and cultural heritage, and the later stanzas cannot be erased merely because some modern listeners find them uncomfortable. But acknowledging the whole composition is not the same as compelling everyone to embrace every line of it. That distinction has sharpened after the Supreme Court stepped in.

On September 22, the Court heard Camatic vocalist T M Krishna's petition challenging the constitutional validity of the 2026 amendment to the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, which punishes intentionally preventing the singing of Vande Mataram or disrupting a gathering engaged in it. A bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant, with Justices Joydalya Bagchi and V Mohana, gave the Centre two weeks to respond.

The bench indicated that someone who declines



to sing all the stanzas on grounds of conscience or religion should not face criminal action. Justice Bagchi cited the 1986 Bijoe Emmanuel judgment, which protected schoolchildren who respectfully declined to sing the National Anthem on religious grounds.

The Court has not yet settled whether official renditions should be limited to two stanzas or extend to all six. The political fight goes on. But the intervention reinforces a constitutional line between respecting a national symbol and compelling an individual to express that respect in a prescribed way. A law may protect a symbol's dignity. It cannot manufacture affection for it.

The controversy has also moved beyond party politics. In Karnataka, the Congress-led government

state government prescribe a different version of a national symbol for official functions? It concerns constitutional competence and Centre-state relations, and the courts must settle it. A party choosing what to sing at its own meeting is one thing; a government directing what must be sung at an official ceremony is another.

The government has a legitimate role in setting protocol for official ceremonies. But protocol should not become a proxy for patriotism.

The BJP should accept that the complete version need not be a litmus test of loyalty. Questioning the later stanzas does not make someone less patriotic, and a party favouring the historically accepted two-stanza version should not be casually branded anti-national. The Congress, for its part,

has ordered that only the first two stanzas be sung at state government programmes, except at functions attended by the President, Vice-President, Prime Minister or Governor.

A petition in the Karnataka High Court challenges the order, arguing that the state cannot prescribe a version different from the Union's official protocol and citing a July 9 Home Ministry communication requiring the official version whenever the National Song is performed. That raises a question weightier than the Congress-BJP quarrel: can a

should recognise that its 1937 position belongs to a specific historical moment. If it backs the two-stanza version today, it owes the country a historical and constitutional explanation, not just an inherited party resolution.

Indian nationalism has never been uniform. It holds many languages, faiths, literary traditions, regional memories and rival readings of the freedom struggle. The Constitution seeks to hold those differences together without demanding that everyone feel the nation in the same way.

The law can punish deliberate insult or disruption, and protocol can decide what is performed at a ceremony. Beyond that lies the democratic space where citizens argue about history, and that space is not disrespect.

There is an irony here. A song that once helped Indians challenge colonial rule is now used to divide them. Vande Mataram belongs to India's history. Its full composition deserves preservation, its role in the freedom struggle deserves remembrance, and its dignity can rightly be protected. But its patriotic worth must not become a weapon to make Indians prove they belong. The challenge is not to decide who owns Vande Mataram, but to ensure that nobody does. India does not need another culture war over a song. It needs the confidence to hold two truths: the song is inseparable from the freedom struggle, and pluralism from the idea of India.

The writer is Deputy Director, Assam Information Centre, New Delhi



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 Order Order

SC dismisses Malegaon poll pleas; AIMIM wins relief

The Supreme Court on Thursday dismissed pleas challenging the election of AIMIM's Mufti Mohammad Ismail Abdul Khaliq as MLA from the Malegaon central constituency in the 2024 Maharashtra assembly polls.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Augustine George Masih and Sandeep Mehta passed the order while hearing two separate petitions challenging a June 8 Bombay High Court judgment.

The high court had rejected an election petition challenging Khaliq's election.

The Maharashtra assembly elections were held in November 2024, and Khaliq was declared elected from the Malegaon central constituency by a margin of 162 votes. One of the candidates who lost the election from the Malegaon Central constituency filed the election petition before the High Court.

The petitioner assailed Khaliq's election, alleging that he committed "corrupt practices" as defined under the Representation of the People Act, 1951.

The election petition claimed that Khaliq was a religious leader and had influenced the minds of the constituency's voters with a "threat of divine displeasure or spiritual censure".

The election petition before the High Court had also alleged that an attempt was made to influence the voters on the grounds of gender by distributing pamphlets that people who elected a woman as their leader could never prosper. Two women candidates were in the fray.

It also claimed that votes were sought on the ground of religion and by appealing to the electorate's religious sentiments.



(PTI)

Delhi HC grants bail to alleged Naga insurgent



The Delhi High Court on Thursday granted bail to alleged Naga insurgent Masasong Ao in a money laundering case being probed by the Enforcement Directorate.

"Bail granted," said Justice Sanjeev Narula while pronouncing the order.

A detailed copy of the verdict is awaited. The money laundering case was lodged in 2021 after the arrest of Alemla Jamir, a self-styled "cabinet minister" of the Nationalist Socialist Council of Nagaland (NSCN)-IM, a banned separatist organisation, in a case registered under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA).

Jamir was intercepted at the Delhi airport on December 17, 2019, while she was about to travel to Dimapur, with ₹72 lakh.

In the UAPA case, the NIA has accused Ao and other members of the insurgent group of helping Jamir run an extortion racket, channel terror funds and commit disruptive acts. The NIA arrested Ao in the case under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) in 2022.

He was arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in February 2020 in the UAPA case and continues to be in custody.

(PTI)

Karnataka cites drought as TN seeks cauvery water

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday asked the Karnataka Government to respond to the Tamil Nadu Government's plea seeking release of its share of the Cauvery River water, alleging a shortfall in supply.

While the Tamil Nadu Government told the apex court that it has already lost an early Kharif crop due to lack of water, the Karnataka Government said it was facing a "terrible drought situation".

The matter came up for hearing before a bench comprising Justices Vikram Nath, Augustine George Masih and Sandeep Mehta.

Senior advocate CS Vaidyanathan, appearing for the Tamil Nadu Government, said the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) must pass an order on the shortfall to address the deficit. "What is the shortfall?" the bench asked. "According to us, it is 20



TMC," Vaidyanathan said.

Senior advocate Shyam Divan, appearing for the Karnataka Government, said they were complying with the CWMA's directions on water release.

"We are complying with whatever directions have been passed even though this is a drought year," he said. "In the present year, we are facing a terrible drought situation.



SC seeks panel on retired judges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday asked the Centre to consider appointing a former high court chief justice as head of the panel to formulate a uniform national policy on post-retirement benefits, such as drivers, security, and stay in Government accommodations for former high court judges while travelling.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was apprised by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta and Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati that the Government has decided to appoint a panel in pursuance of an earlier direction.

The law officers told the bench that a former secretary-level officer has been appointed to head the committee.

"I think a former Chief Justice of the High Court should preside over the committee," the CJI said.

The Solicitor General agreed with the suggestions and said the Government would come back to the



bench on September 28.

On August 20, the bench granted the Centre one more week to set up the panel.

Earlier, on July 20, the bench asked the Centre to set up a panel within two weeks to recommend a uniform national policy on post-retirement benefits, such as driver services, security, and stay in Government accommodations while travelling, for former High Court judges.

It also directed the panel to submit its report within three months.

The bench was hearing a contempt petition filed by Justice VS Dave, president of the Association of Retired Judges of the Supreme Court and High Courts, raising the issue of security and other

facilities for retired judges.

During the hearing, the CJI questioned the adequacy of the financial assistance some states currently provide to engage security personnel and drivers.

"In ₹45,000-50,000, is it possible to get a driver and a security officer?" the CJI asked. "There is a lack of uniformity among states. One way is for the Government of India to constitute a committee and prescribe norms. The central Government may also match grants. If you don't do it, I will have to constitute one," the CJI told the Solicitor General.

The law officer said the Government had no difficulty in constituting such a committee. "There is no difficul-

ty. We can constitute it.

"This is an issue which needs to be addressed. It will be addressed in the spirit expressed," Mehta said.

In its order, the bench said the proceedings concern the admissibility of various post-retirement benefits and facilities to retired chief justices and judges of high courts.

"The issue that falls for consideration in these proceedings revolves around certain benefits/facilities to be made admissible to retired Chief Justices and judges of high courts," the court said.

The order noted that basic facilities such as domestic help, drivers, telephone facilities, medical reimbursement and retention of Government accommodation vary considerably from one state to another.

"Basic facilities like domestic help, driver, telephone, medical reimbursement, stay in Government houses, etc., vary from state to state. It further appears that the lack of uniformity has prompted the Association of Retired Judges to first approach the authorities and thereafter invoke the writ jurisdiction of this court," the bench said.

Allahabad HC says courts can raise accident claim awards

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Allahabad High Court has held that an appellate court can enhance compensation awarded in a motor accident claim even when the victims or their dependants have not filed a separate appeal or cross-objection, provided the insurer has challenged the quantum of compensation.

Justice Prashant Kumar of the Lucknow bench of the court on Wednesday observed that the Motor Vehicles Act is beneficial legislation and courts must ensure that victims and their dependants receive just and fair compensation in accordance with law.

The court observed while dismissing an appeal filed by the National Insurance Company Ltd against an award of the Faizabad Motor Accident Claims Tribunal.

Calcutta HC questions ECI move on TMC symbols

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday came down heavily on the Election Commission over reassignment of the 'envelope' symbol to the newly formed Democratic Trinamool Congress from the ISF, observing that the poll panel "should act fairly".

Noting that the EC has 183 free election symbols at its disposal, the court asked why the Commission gave the 'envelope' symbol to a party contesting the by-election in West Bengal's Nandigram, where the ISF has also fielded a candidate.

The court verbally observed that the symbol should have been kept reserved. "The authority should act fairly," Justice Krishna Rao observed.

The High Court adjourned the hearing until Friday on a prayer by the EC's counsel to take instructions on why a notification was not issued for allotment of symbols for the



bypolls.

Justice Rao asked why the EC was creating a dispute by allotting the 'envelope' symbol to the new party.

"Your authority is pinching the persons and creating legal proceedings; is this the way of the authority to work?" Justice Rao told the EC's lawyer during the hearing of the ISF petition, challenging the reassignment of the 'envelope' symbol.

"Every time for one reason or another you are compelling the persons to come to court," he observed.



The tribunal had awarded ₹7.20 lakh to the family of one Sabhajet Tadmali. The high court enhanced the compensation to ₹11,43,565 and retained interest at 7 per cent per annum.

The accident took place on November 16, 2017, when Tadmali was walking near Bariyawan crossing in Ambedkar Nagar. An SUV allegedly hit him, leaving him seriously injured. He died during treatment. His family had sought compensation of ₹49.70 lakh.

The insurance company argued that the vehicle had

been stolen before the accident and was not in the possession of its owner or driver at the relevant time. It also questioned the driver's identity, pointing to a discrepancy in his name in the chargesheet and driving licence records.

Rejecting the theft plea, the court noted that the vehicle owner had neither lodged an FIR nor produced any cogent evidence to establish that the SUV had been stolen before the accident. The court also held that the discrepancy in the driver's name was insufficient to disbelieve the prosecution and claimants' case.

On the deceased's age, the court held that the age recorded in Aadhaar could not be treated as conclusive proof of his date of birth. The family register showed his year of birth as 1967, though the exact date and month were unavailable.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow



developer offered possession only in May 2017 and, according to the court, did so without the occupancy certificate and other necessary documents.

The RERA Appellate Tribunal directed the developer to pay interest on the amount Agrawal deposited for the period from December 2012 to May 2017 at a rate of one per cent above the Marginal Cost of Fund Based Lending Rate.

The developer challenged the order, contending that the delay was caused by a

National Green Tribunal (NGT) order restraining construction and the grant of occupancy certificates within a 10-km radius of the Okhla Bird Sanctuary.

The high court rejected the contention, noting that the developer's own case was that the project had been completed in 2014 and an application for the occupancy certificate had also been made that year. It could not, therefore, simultaneously claim that the project was complete and that the NGT restraint had prevented its completion.

The court further noted that the NGT restriction came into effect in August 2013, whereas the contractual deadline for handing over possession was November 2012. The order said the developer's default had already occurred before the restriction came into force.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday agreed to list for hearing next week a PIL seeking directions to the Centre and state authorities to install display boards at public institutions, including police stations, court premises and municipal offices, informing people about the legal consequences of lodging false complaints.

Advocate Ashwini Upadhyay mentioned the matter before a bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya

Bagchi and V Mohana, seeking listing of his plea.

The top court had earlier issued notices to the Centre and states seeking their response to Upadhyay's public interest litigation (PIL).

The plea has also sought directions for state authorities to inform the complainant about punishment for false complaints, false charges, false statements, false information and false evidence before accepting the complaint, to secure the freedom of speech and expression of innocent citizens.

Upadhyay has further



sought directions to state authorities to take an undertaking or an affidavit that the averments made in the complaint, information, statement, evidence, and charges are true and correct, to

control false complaints and frivolous cases.

"Empirical data compiled from NCRB reports demonstrates a stark disparity between cases registered and convictions under

several special criminal laws, with acquittals running into disproportionately high numbers. This statistical pattern reveals a structural problem of false complaints, false charges and fabricated evidence clogging the criminal justice system," the plea stated.

It referred to the Law Commission in Report number 277, saying that it "expressly identified false charges, fabricated evidence and wrongful prosecutions as primary causes of miscarriage of justice and violations of Article 21."

"Chapter XIV of the BNS

2023 has specific provisions to address these menaces. But Centre and States have not taken apposite steps to implement them," the plea filed through advocate Ashwani Dubey said.

The plea has also sought directions to inform a complainant about the punishment for filing false cases and false information.

"Direct respondents to take an undertaking/affidavit that averments made in Complaint, Statement, Evidence and Charges are true and correct, to control false complaints and frivolous cases," the plea said.

Aaya Ram, gaya Ram : SC rejects BRS MLA Nagender's defection plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday dismissed BRS MLA Danam Nagender's plea challenging a Telangana High Court order that disqualified him after he defected to the ruling Congress, observing it was a case of 'Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram'.

The high court had set aside an order of the Assembly Speaker in March this year dismissing petitions seeking his disqualification.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana said there was no ground to interfere with the high court's order. "Your case is 'Aaya Ram, Gaya Ram, phir aaya Ram'?" Justice Bagchi remarked orally.

The phrase describes politicians who frequently switch sides.



Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi appeared for the BRS MLA.

The high court had declared Nagender, MLA from Khairatabad, disqualified from April 23, 2024, as a member of the Telangana Legislative Assembly, after contesting from the Secunderabad Lok Sabha constituency on the Congress ticket in 2024 while serving as a BRS MLA.

The court passed the order while dealing with petitions filed by BJP floor leader in the Assembly Alleti

Maheshwar Reddy and P Kaushik Reddy of BRS.

The petitioners sought to quash and set aside the Speaker's order and to declare that Nagender be disqualified as MLA as per the 2(1)(a) of the Tenth Schedule from the date of filing of the nomination affidavit for the 2024 General Lok Sabha elections.

Telangana Legislative Assembly Speaker Gaddam Prasad Kumar on March 11 dismissed petitions seeking Nagender's disqualification as a legislator.

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Myntra creates over 26,000 gigs ahead of festive season

Fashion and lifestyle e-commerce platform Myntra on Thursday said it has created more than 26,000 seasonal employment opportunities ahead of the festive season and its 'Big Fashion Festival'. The hiring represents more than a two-fold increase in seasonal hiring compared to the previous year, the company said in a statement.

Of the total seasonal positions, over 350 roles have been reserved for persons with disabilities, while women will constitute 30 per cent of the fulfilment centre workforce. The seasonal roles encompass supply chain operations, such as sorting, grading and packing, with 8,000 delivery partners and 2,700 customer service roles rounding out the seasonal team. The workforce has been recruited from several states, including Odisha, Karnataka, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Jharkhand, to support operations across five fulfilment hubs located in Bengaluru, Mumbai, Kolkata, Bilaspur and Binola. Myntra said the additional workforce will strengthen its operational and delivery capacity during the festive surge, supporting express services such as 'M-Express', which offers product delivery within 24 to 48 hours in select locations.

"From recognising everyday champions to creating opportunities for women and differently abled individuals, we want to build an environment where people can bring their best through the Big Fashion Festival," Govindraj MK, CHRO, Myntra, said. (PTI)

GMR Hospitality to operate outlets at Delhi airport's T3

GMR Hospitality Ltd has been selected for setting up, operating and maintaining food and beverages outlets at the Terminal 3 of the Delhi airport.

The company has won the contract for an initial period up to May 2036 that can up extended by another 10 years, and has entered into a license agreement with Delhi International Airport Ltd (DIAL), according to a regulatory filing. GMR Hospitality Ltd (GHL) and DIAL, which operates the Indira Gandhi International Airport in the national capital, are part of the GMR Group.

"The licence fee is based on the revenue share payment model to DIAL which would be ascertained based on the revenue from Food & Beverages Outlets on year on year basis with a minimum monthly guarantee payable by GHL to DIAL & advertisement fees.

"The estimated aggregate amount of licence fees for 2026-27 and FY 2027-28 shall be – ₹49 crores and – ₹109 crores, respectively," GMR Airports Ltd (GAL) said in the regulatory filing late evening on Wednesday.

GHL has emerged as the selected bidder for designing, financing, developing, setting up, operating, managing and maintaining the food and beverages outlets at Terminal 3. The transaction is a related party transaction on arms' length basis and necessary approvals were duly obtained in accordance with Sebi Listing Regulations and Companies Act, 2013, the filing said.

GMR Hospitality – a joint venture between GMR Airports and Travel Food Services – operates food and beverages outlets at Goa and Hyderabad airports.

GMR Airports operates airports at Delhi, Hyderabad, Goa, Nagpur, Bidar as well as Kualanamu International Airport in Medan, Indonesia. (PTI)

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | SEPTEMBER 25, 2026

MeitY pushes for indigenous chips

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government has started a consultation process to explore development of indigenous power semiconductors and modules for power grids.

The Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY), along with the Power Ministry and Powergrid, on Thursday invited industry players for a pre-Request For Proposal (RFP) stakeholder consultation to gather input before issuing the final proposal.

"Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY), Ministry of Power and Powergrid invite you for a Pre-RFP Stakeholder Consultation for the indigenous design, development, qualification and supply of SiC MOSFET-based power modules for VSC-HVDC," MeitY said in a social media post.

VSC-HVDC (Voltage-Sourced Converter High-

Voltage Direct Current) is an advanced power transmission technology that uses semiconductors to convert electricity waves according to the requirements of all electrical appliances across homes, offices and industries. According to details shared by MeitY on its website, the initiative aims to build domestic capability across the power semiconductor value chain - device design, module engineering, fabrication, packaging,

assembly, testing, qualification and system integration. Interested entities can send their queries and suggestions by October 8 and the consultation is scheduled to be held on October 14. The objective of the government is to reduce dependence on imported technology for strategic grid applications. Electricity grids in the country, classified as critical infrastructure, are highly dependent on imported equipment.

Consultancy firm McKinsey, in a report, said that in the absence of effort to indigenise power gears, the industry could face a production shortfall of more than \$ 130 billion that could push import dependence to meet domestic and export demand beyond 70 per cent and conflict with India's objective of self-reliance.

"This could become India's largest import category, rivaling oil and gas," the McKinsey report said. According to the report, India's consumption of electrical equipment grew to \$59 billion, an increase of \$ 24 billion between 2020 and 2025.

In 2025, India produced only USD 32 billion for the domestic market, excluding imports; consequently, India imported USD 15 billion more in 2025 relative to 2020, sharply increasing its import dependence from 22 to 33 per cent.

Gold slides ₹1,600 to ₹1.52 lakh per 10 gm as oil surges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Gold prices declined ₹1,600 to ₹1.52 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Thursday, extending the losing streak for the fourth consecutive session, as the rising US dollar and higher crude oil prices weighed on the precious metal. The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity depreciated by ₹1,600 to ₹1,52,400 per 10 grams, inclusive of all taxes, from Wednesday's closing

level of ₹1.54 lakh per 10 grams, according to local traders.

Silver, meanwhile, saw a downward momentum after remaining unchanged for the past two sessions, tumbling

₹5,000 to ₹2.37 lakh per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes). The white metal had settled at ₹2.42 lakh per kg in the previous session. The continued selloff in gold pushed the metal deeper into a four-session decline, with traders attributing the weakness to weak global trends and profit-taking at elevated levels.

Silver took a bigger hit as its greater volatility and exposure to industrial demand amplified the selling pressure, ending the day well below its

previous close, traders said. The rupee's slide to 95.96 against the US dollar offered some cushion to domestic bullion prices, limiting the extent of decline, they added.

According to Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst of Commodities at HDFC Securities, domestic gold prices edged lower amid weak global cues and subdued retail demand.

He noted that a stronger US dollar and rising Treasury yields continued to weigh on precious metals.

Rupee plunges 23 paise to 95.96 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee weakened by 23 paise to settle at 95.96 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday, dragged by a surge in crude oil prices and a strong greenback amid geopolitical uncertainties. According to forex traders, the domestic currency was also weighed down by heavy selling in domestic equity markets as investors moved toward risk aversion, adding strength to the dollar, even as rising inflation concerns pushed US bond yields higher.

yield surged over 15 basis points from Tuesday's settlement, while the five-year yield crossed 5 per cent for the first time since 2007," Makda said, adding, "The immediate resistance rests at the psychological 96.00 threshold, where a clean breakout could trigger accelerated depreciation for the rupee, while immediate downside support sits around 95.43. Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, traded at 100.99, up 0.18 per cent."

Brent crude futures, the global oil benchmark, were trading sharply higher by 2.74 per cent at \$105.90 per barrel compared to the roughly \$72 per barrel level from late February before the Iran war.

Analysts said that oil prices that began stabilising in the last few sessions climbed again past \$100 a barrel due to a lack of diplomatic progress over the West Asia peace efforts after the US and Iranian officials met on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York.

"In the US, surprisingly resilient purchasing managers' index (PMI) data reignited inflationary fears, while weak demand at a five-year Treasury debt auction drove yields significantly higher — the 10-year

Assam expanding beyond traditional sectors: Finance Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Assam Finance Minister Jayanta Mallabaruah today highlighted the State's human resource as its greatest strength for industrialisation, saying that the ongoing investment-led transformation must translate into quality employment, entrepreneurship and economic opportunities for the youth within Assam.

Addressing the 13th SBI Banking & Economics Conclave at The Taj Mahal Palace, Mumbai, Baruah said Assam is expanding beyond its traditional economic strengths of tea, petroleum and agriculture and building new growth ecosystems across semiconductors, electronics, food processing, tourism, logistics, renewable energy, healthcare,

aerospace and defence.

"Assam's greatest resource for industrialisation is its human resource, and that makes Assam one of the most attractive destinations for investment today," Baruah said.

Baruah said the State's approach, under the leadership of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, focuses on strengthening infrastructure and human

capital, undertaking business-friendly reforms, introducing sector-specific policies, and improving single-window mechanisms to facilitate investment.

Highlighting the emerging industrial ecosystem, the Minister cited the approximately ₹27,000 crore semiconductor facility in Morigaon. He also highlighted the ₹778 crore PepsiCo India food manufacturing

NBCC hands over allotment letter to SBER India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NBCC (India) Limited, a Navratna CPSE under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, on the evening of September 23 handed over the allotment letter and agreement to sale document for two towers at its Bharat Business Park (BBP), Sarojini Nagar, to SBER India, in one of the largest purchases of Indian office space by a foreign bank.

Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC, handed over the documents to Igor Shishkin, Deputy Managing Director, SBER India, at Corporate Headquarter, New Delhi in the presence of Dr Suman

Kumar, Director (Commercial), Anjeev Kumar Jain, Director (Finance), Dr Vijay Choudhary, Senior Executive Director (Finance), NBCC and other senior officers from both organisations.

The two towers cover approximately 5.17 lakh sq ft of super built-up area having a sale value of more than ₹2,000 crore. SBER Bank

secured them through a competitive e-auction in April 2026, making it the largest single buyer at the project. SBER India has announced plans to set up a Russian Business Centre in New Delhi. The centre will support Russian companies operating in India with banking, legal, tax and audit services. In total, NBCC has

successfully sold all the 8 towers spanning approximately 23.44 lakh sq ft, for about ₹10,000 crore. The project is expected to be completed in 2028.

Other buyers include leading public sector organisations such as IRCTC, Government e-Marketplace (GeM), BPCL, RVNL and National Land Monetisation Corporation Ltd and others.

Speaking on the occasion, Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC, said, "SBER India's decision to make Bharat Business Park its home in Delhi is a strong endorsement of NBCC's execution capability and of Delhi as a destination for global business."

From 1% to 10% by 2035: India's seed industry sets its sights on global market

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

India's seed industry has spent decades supplying its own farmers. Now it wants a share of everyone else's. The Federation of Seed Industry of India (FSII) said on Thursday that the sector aims to raise India's share of global seed trade from around 1 per cent to 10 per cent by 2035, while strengthening domestic innovation and self-reliance in crops considered strategically important, such as oilseeds and pulses.

The goal was set out at FSII Knowledge Day 2026, held as part of the federation's 10th Annual General Meeting in

New Delhi. FSII said the industry, currently valued at \$3.6 billion and expected to cross \$5 billion by 2030, would contribute to Atmanirbharta in line with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision.

FSII Chairman and Savannah Seeds MD & CEO Ajai Rana said India has the science, talent and farmers to become a major player in the global seed market, calling government initiatives such as the national Mission on High-Yielding Seeds important steps. He said the industry was ready to invest more in research, particularly in oilseeds and pulses.

Outlining the industry's

demands, Rana called for a single national framework for seed regulation with predictable timelines, faster science-based approvals for new varieties, traits and technologies, and stronger intellectual property protection, especially in oilseeds and pulses, saying this would give companies confidence to make long-term investments.

Rana said there was merit in giving a decisive push to R&D investment, noting that while developed countries spend about 3 to 4 per cent of GDP on R&D, India's investment remains below 1 per cent, even though research suggests every rupee spent on R&D can

Seed industry experts launched the report on vegetable seed market on 10th AGM of FSII
PIONEER PHOTO

yield a return of ₹13.

On edible oil import dependence, Rana said government and industry working together could achieve self-sufficiency in edible oil in under 10 years.

He said the industry has developed mustard hybrids yielding one tonne per acre, adding significantly to farmer incomes compared to wheat, and that diverting some land from wheat to

mustard could meaningfully boost farmer income while reducing import dependence.

Kishore Jaiswal, progressive farmer and Convenor of the National Farmers' Empowerment Initiative, said farmers adopt better seed once they see results in their fields, with good seed delivering higher yields and better protection against pests and bad weather.

He said Indian farmers want access to the latest seed technologies at the same time as farmers in other countries.

Dr K Vijayaraghavan, Chairman and CEO of Sathguru Management Consultants, Hyderabad,

cited findings from a report on India's vegetable seed sector showing 93 percent of vegetable farmers across five major producing states use hybrid seed, with 68 percent sourcing it through dealers.

He said improved seed was translating into economic value, with an average cultivation cost of Rs 1.07 lakh per acre and an average reported return on investment of 2.7 times, with 85 percent of farmers reporting improved crop resilience and 61 percent considering contemporary varieties climate-ready.

The report, "Transformation of India's Vegetable Seed Sector," was

prepared by Sathguru Management Consultants and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Netherlands.

The report's findings also pointed to an opportunity to unlock further value, noting that awareness and adoption of specific climate and biotic-stress traits remain limited, with farmers continuing to rely on generic pesticide applications for crop protection.

Also present at the event were FSII Director General Dr Paresh Verma, Marion van Schaik, Counsellor for Agriculture at the Embassy of the Kingdom of the Netherlands in New Delhi, and Dr Manish Diwan, GGM and Head of RDF at BIRAC.

4. The promoter has submitted a request for change of the designated bank accounts before the Authority, which is presently under consideration.

5. This notice is being issued for information purposes only to the general public, allottees, and stakeholders in respect of the above-mentioned project.

Sd/-
Secretary
For Haryana Real Estate Regulatory
Authority, Gurugram

Dated: 25.09.2026

Russian drone strikes kill eight in Ukraine

HANNA ARHIROVA/
BARRY HATTON ■ Kyiv

Russian drone and missile attacks on Ukraine overnight killed at least eight civilians, officials said on Thursday, as Moscow's four-and-a-half year-long invasion of its neighbour grinds on despite renewed appeals for a settlement at this week's UN General Assembly.

A strike on Ukraine's north-eastern Kharkiv region killed six agricultural workers and wounded 12 others, Interior Minister Ihor Vyhivskiy said. An attack on the Capital Kyiv killed a man and a woman, he said, while officials in the southern port of Odesa also reported a major bombardment. Ukrainian



President Volodymyr Zelenskyy appealed in a speech at the United Nations late on Wednesday for countries to starve Russia of

revenue through sanctions and trade bans, denying Moscow the money it needs to prolong the war. He and other leaders at

previous UN general assemblies have sought to pressure Moscow into giving up its ambitions in Ukraine. But despite years of diplo-

matic efforts there is no sign of a breakthrough in ending a war that has had repercussions for the global food and energy supply, as well as severely straining relations between Russia and Western countries.

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov repeated Moscow's demand for a comprehensive peace deal, not a temporary break in hostilities, following Ukraine's call for a complete and unconditional ceasefire. "We believe it's necessary to seek peace, not a temporary truce," Peskov told reporters on Thursday.

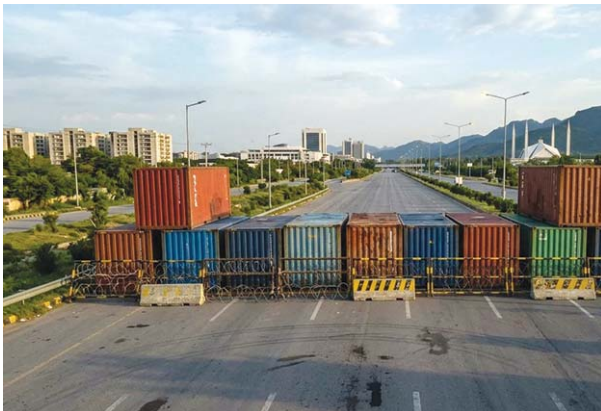
Russia's demands for Ukraine to surrender its territory, among other things, are unacceptable for Kyiv. The aerial war has intensified in

recent months. Russia keeps hammering Ukraine with cruise and ballistic missiles, powerful glide bombs and jet-powered drones, while Ukraine's long-range drones target oil refineries and businesses that are a vital part of the Russian economy.

There have been few significant changes since last year along the roughly 1,250-kilometer (800-mile) front line in eastern and southern Ukraine, where a huge number of drones on both sides limit movement.

The attack on Kyiv damaged more than 50 civilian sites, including apartment blocks, post offices, a maternity hospital and a textile plant, Vyhivskiy, the interior minister, said. (PTI)

Public gatherings banned in Islamabad ahead of PTI protest



SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistani authorities have banned public gatherings in Islamabad for two months ahead of a march planned by jailed former prime minister Imran Khan's political party to the Capital. The Islamabad administration, in an order on Wednesday, said that Section 144 of the Criminal Procedure Code had been imposed, prohibiting gatherings of five or more people, processions, rallies and demonstrations across the federal capital, including the high-security Red Zone. The development comes after Islamabad Additional District Magistrate

Anam Fatima issued an order on September 18, stating that Section 144 of the Criminal Procedure Code had been enforced with immediate effect and "shall remain in force for a period of two months."

The move comes as Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) prepares for a long march to Islamabad on September 27, primarily demanding the release of the party founder, who has been incarcerated in connection with multiple cases since 2023.

The leaders of Khan's PTI party said the protest would also demand constitutional supremacy and the rule of law. (PTI)

Turkiye to hand over key Iraq military base to Baghdad

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Ankara

Turkiye has agreed to gradually withdraw forces from a strategic military base in northern Iraq and hand over its control to the Iraqi Government, following a meeting between the two countries' leaders on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York.

Iraq, meanwhile, pledged to remove armed groups that Türkiye considers security threats from the region of Sinjar, in northwestern Iraq, according to a joint statement issued after the meeting late Wednesday between Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan and Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi. "In light of the progress



Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan meets Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in New York

Iraq has achieved through security measures, Turkish forces will gradually hand over the Bashiqa-Zelikan camp to the Iraqi federal government, in accordance with the agreed-upon mechanism and timeline," according to the joint statement

released by Erdogan and al-Zaidi's offices.

Turkiye and Iraq also agreed to "fully extend the authority of the Iraqi state in Sinjar and to end the presence of banned foreign armed elements," the statement read. The strate-

gically-located Bashiqa base has long been an issue of contention between Türkiye and Iraq, with Türkiye failing to fully withdraw forces, despite previous discussions for their removal. Türkiye established a military presence there in 2015 to support operations against the Islamic State group and help secure the region.

Although Türkiye maintains several bases in northern Iraq for operations against the militant Kurdistan Workers' Party, the Bashiqa camp is Türkiye's furthest base from its border. Türkiye, for its part, has long been pressing Iraq to curb groups with links to the PKK and other armed groups from operating in Sinjar.

Najeeb Naqi of PML-N elected as PoK President

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Najeeb Naqi of the ruling Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) was on Thursday elected as the "President" of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK).

He secured 32 votes, while his challenger Chaudhry Latif Akbar of Pakistan Peoples Party got 13 votes in the election held at PoK's so-called legislative assembly. Only assembly members were eligible to vote.

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif congratulated Naqi on his victory and conveyed his best wishes, according to a statement issued by



the PM's office. Naqi has previously served as health minister. The office of "president" had been vacant since January following the death of Sultan Mahmood Chaudhry.

India has described the recent so-called local body elections in PoK as a "complete farce," asserting that such "hollow" exercises cannot hide the ground reality in the region. (PTI)

Zelenskyy urges India, others to block Russian recruitments

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy has urged countries to protect their citizens from being recruited into Russia's war against Ukraine, alleging that Moscow has used deceptive methods to enlist people from dozens of nations.

Addressing the 81st United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) in New York on Wednesday, Zelenskyy said nationals from at least 47 countries were involved in the conflict on Russia's side. He specifically mentioned citizens of India, Nepal, Ghana, Tajikistan, Yemen, Kenya, Zimbabwe, Cuba, Belarus, Sudan and South Africa, among others.

According to Zelenskyy, some foreign nationals reached Russia after being misled about the nature of the work or circumstances they



would face. "We know that Russia uses citizens of 47 countries in its war," Zelenskyy said, calling on Governments to take steps to

prevent their nationals from becoming involved in the fighting.

Zelenskyy appealed directly to countries whose citizens are reportedly serving with Russian forces, urging them to intervene and safeguard their nationals. He also criticised Russian President Vladimir Putin's conduct of the war and called on governments to restrict Russia's ability to continue its military campaign.

"Do not let Putin drag you into this war," Zelenskyy said, while urging countries to limit Russia's financial resources and capacity to sustain the conflict. India's Ministry of External Affairs has previously disclosed figures concerning Indian nationals recruited into the Russian armed forces.

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said earlier this month that 227 Indian nationals had been recruit-

ed. Of those, 139 had subsequently been discharged, while 51 had died, according to figures cited by the ministry. New Delhi has continued discussions with Moscow regarding the release and return of the Indians who remain in Russia.

The Indian Government has also maintained that efforts are underway to secure the early discharge and repatriation of Indian nationals who were recruited into the Russian military.

During his UN address, Zelenskyy also called for greater international pressure on Russia's sources of war financing.

He said Ukraine's objective in targeting Russia's economic capabilities was not simply to damage oil facilities, fuel infrastructure, factories or ports. Rather, he argued that reducing Russia's revenues would make it more difficult for Moscow

to sustain the war. "Russia's finances and Russia's production are what must be stopped if Putin is to be stopped," Zelenskyy said.

The Ukrainian president has also urged countries including India, China and Turkey to reduce their energy trade with Russia. In comments reported by The Wall Street Journal, Zelenskyy argued that Russia's economy depends significantly on energy relationships with these countries and suggested that reduced purchases could increase pressure on Moscow.

India, however, has consistently said that its crude oil purchases are based on market conditions and the country's energy-security requirements. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman has said India's energy policy takes into account the interests of consumers as well as the wider Indian economy.

Indonesia commissions first aircraft carrier

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Jakarta

Indonesia's navy commissioned its first aircraft carrier on Thursday after acquiring the former Italian vessel to strengthen its maritime defences and disaster response.

The Italian flag on the former ITS Giuseppe Garibaldi was replaced with the Indonesian flag on the carrier renamed the KRI Sriwijaya-100 as part of its official transfer at the ceremony held at Tanjung Priok seaport in North Jakarta.

"The ship, which previously served in the Italian Navy, now bears the name KRI Sriwijaya-100, flying the red-and-white flag as a symbol of sovereignty and service to Indonesia," navy spokesperson Tunggal, who



uses one name, said in a statement. The carrier, which Italy retired in 2024, arrived at the Indonesian seaport last week after a 25-day journey passing through the Suez Canal, the Red Sea and the Indian Ocean. It has the capacity for short takeoff

and vertical landing aircraft and helicopters.

Unlike major naval powers, Indonesia will use the vessel as a mobile command and support hub for helicopters, drones and maritime operations across the archipelago.

President Prabowo Subianto earlier said the ship would help fight forest and peatland fires that regularly blanket parts of Southeast Asia with hazardous haze.

Italy agreed in March to give the carrier to Indonesia in a move aimed at boosting Italy's broader defense engagement with the Southeast Asian country.

Italy is seeking deals on submarines and aircraft, and gifting the carrier to Indonesia also saves it the cost of decommissioning the ship.

Indonesia is the second country in Southeast Asia with an aircraft carrier. Thailand's HTMS Chakri Naruebet was commissioned in 1997 after being procured from Spain.

UN institutions losing effectiveness: Indian expert

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New York

The effectiveness of the UN has been increasingly questioned, particularly in matters of war and peace, an eminent Indian expert has said.

Speaking to PTI Videos, ORF America's Executive Director Dhruva Jaishankar, however, stressed that there are still many institutions that continue to matter and cited the UN's work in public health and development as examples.

On the broader relevance of the UN amid conflicts in West Asia and Ukraine, he underlined how the UN's effectiveness was increasingly being questioned, particularly in matters of war and peace. "We are at a point in time where it's quite clear that the existing multilateral insti-



tutions, not just the United Nations, but others as well, are starting to wear out their utility and effectiveness."

"They still matter for many reasons, and there are many examples of them doing good work, say for the United Nations on public health initiatives around the world

and the development of gender as convening power for the UN General Assembly."

"But I think it's quite, even people who work at the United Nations are quite sceptical of its effectiveness today," he added.

He also said that the United

Nations Security Council reform remains a long way off, with China's reluctance, competing reform proposals and the lack of consensus among African countries posing major hurdles to India's bid for a permanent seat.

"There are many reasons why it's not happening. One is actually some of the P5, the permanent members, particularly China, are reluctant for this reform," he said, while noting that France has been among the most forward-leaning countries on the issue and that the US has been "quite ambivalent".

"Another group, which includes Pakistan, is seeking to prevent any expansion of the permanent category of Security Council members," he said.

Long truck queues strain Turkiye-Iran crossing amid escalating US naval blockade

SERRA YEDIKARDES/
AMIR-HUSSEIN RADJY ■ Ankara

Hundreds of trucks idle along the road into Iran from Türkiye's mountainous eastern border. Busting even in normal times, the countries' largest crossing is now a make-or-break economic lifeline for Tehran as the US navy blockades its ports.

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian has pressed to accelerate overland trade as the blockade limits the vast majority of imports while cutting off the oil and gas sales that largely keep the economy alive.

It's the latest test of Iran's endurance. Frustrated Iranian truck drivers spoke to The Associated Press at the Türkiye

border crossing, where lines now stretch for miles.

"I've been driving through this border gate for 15 years. I've never had to wait as long as now," said Muhammed Riza Shiri, 55, who had waited four days to carry his load of rubber into Iran. "We had to wait at the end of a seven-kilometer (4.3-mile) line. We used to wait, maximum, for three days here. Because of the war, the waiting times exceed five days."

Iran accuses the US of trying to weaken the country.

"They are trying to create difficulties wherever they can, and they are holding nothing back. They are closing off routes, shutting down air routes, blocking land routes and trying to fuel internal divisions," President Masoud Pezeshkian said.



Hundreds of trucks line up at Türkiye's eastern border crossing into Iran

Iran insists the pressure will not change its stance in negotiations with Washington. Tehran wants the US blockade to end before it allows commercial shipping to flow again through the Strait of Hormuz, where Iran's grip has shaken global markets and oil prices.

Iran has a huge challenge as it tries to shift trade from sea to land. Its economy relied on the gulf for over 80 per cent of its trade before the war, according to Iran economist Mohammad Farzanegan.

Now Iran's land crossings with Türkiye to the west and Pakistan to the east are crucial in connecting with Europe and Asia. Drivers carry goods that are vital to Iran's petrochemical and other manufacturing that were badly damaged by US and Israeli strikes.

But the land crossings are badly strained. "Logistics, capacities of these borders are limited."

At Türkiye's Gurbulak border, truck waiting times have more than quadrupled since the war began, according to data from the International Transporters Association, which represents Türkiye's international logistics sector. "Instead of 200 trucks, there are 1,200 trucks at the border, and the destination country does not have the capacity to accept this number of trucks," Amir Roshanbakhsh Ghanbari, deputy head for a Government agency that promotes Iranian trade, said in an interview with a semiofficial news outlet, ILNA. Ghanbari blamed the border backup in part on neighbouring countries: "Destination coun-

tries are not willing to develop infrastructure because it is not clear how long this situation will continue."

But an AP reporter visiting the Türkiye border crossing on Tuesday saw road work aimed at building extra lanes. Two staffers from a local road authority, who spoke on condition of anonymity as they were not authorized to comment publicly, said Türkiye was improving border infrastructure based on a three-year-old plan.

A Telegram channel linked with groups representing Iranian truckers and other transportation drivers is flooded with messages protesting conditions.

Their low-wage work is further squeezed after Iranian authorities raised fuel prices and tightened fuel quotas. (AP)

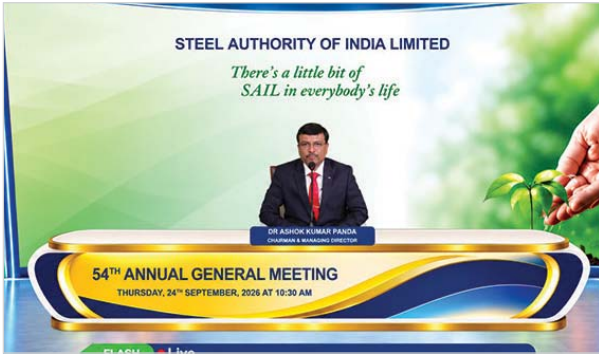
SAIL's 54th AGM highlights value-added steel growth

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Steel Authority of India Limited (SAIL) held its 54th Annual General Meeting (AGM) today on 24.09.2026, in hybrid mode at CSOI, New Delhi. Addressing the shareholders, Chairman and Managing Director Dr AK Panda presented the Company's performance for FY 2025-26 and outlined its strategic priorities for the years ahead.

SAIL CMD, Dr Panda, noted that despite a challenging global steel environment marked by geopolitical uncertainties and market volatility, India continued to lead global steel demand growth, retaining its position as the world's fastest-growing major steel producer. He stated that, "SAIL demonstrated strong resilience and adaptability, achieving new benchmarks driven by technological upgrades, financial prudence, digitalisation, HR initiatives and sustainability efforts."

Dr Panda emphasised that, "SAIL's performance during



the year was marked not only by best ever crude steel, finished steel and saleable steel production, but also a strong focus towards value creation. The Company produced 10.7 million tonnes (MT) of value added steel, which was 56% of total saleable steel, up by 7 per cent over FY'24-25.

It introduced 28 new products across infrastructure, automotive, energy and manufacturing sectors, significantly strengthening SAIL's ability to meet evolving national and sectoral requirements. He added that this enhanced product capability

directly reinforced SAIL's nation building role.

In FY 2025-26, the Company dispatched the first consignment of indigenously developed Vande Bharat wheels and supplied steel for five Indian Navy ships — INS Arnala, Udaygiri, Himgiri, Androth and Anjadeep — commissioned during the year.

Highlighting the Company's financial performance, Dr Panda said, "Reflecting operational efficiency, in FY 2025-26 SAIL posted its highest-ever revenue, surpassing ₹1,09,000 crore, an 8 per cent increase over the previous year. The

Company reduced borrowings by more than ₹5,000 crore through judicious fund management. With higher sales volume, lower inventory and reduced borrowings, the Company's profitability strengthened, and both PBT & PAT improved by 44 per cent and 50.5 per cent respectively. The Board has recommended a Final Dividend of ₹2.35 per equity share."

Reinforcing the Company's sustainability focus, CMD shared that SAIL generated 5.61 million units of green power from the first 4 MW floating solar plant at IISCO Steel Plant, with a 20 MW floating solar plant underway at Bhilai Steel Plant.

Looking ahead, Dr Panda stated that "SAIL is focused on expanding crude steel capacity to ~35 MTPA by FY 2030-31, supported by green capacity creation, adoption of low carbon technologies, digital enablement, enhanced customer engagement, increased share of value added and special steels, and deeper integration with retail and MSME ecosystems."

AIIA marks 11th Ayurveda Day with rally, seminar, book launches

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The All India Institute of Ayurveda (AIIA), an autonomous organisation under the Ministry of Ayush, Government of India, celebrated the 11th Ayurveda Day-2026 at its campus with a series of academic, awareness and outreach activities. The organisation organised two major programmes as part of the celebrations.

To mark the occasion, the organisation organised an "Ayurveda Public Awareness Rally" in the morning to promote Ayurveda, propagate its principles, and raise public awareness of Ayurveda's role in healthy living and holistic healthcare.

Professor (Vaidya) PK Prajapati, Director, AIIA, participated in the rally along with Professor (Dr) Manjusha Rajagopala, Dean, DU; Professor (Dr) Mahesh Vyas, Dean, PhD; Professor (Dr) Ramakant Yadav, Dean, PG; Dr Yogesh Badwe, MS; and



faculty members, non-faculty members, PhD and postgraduate (PG) scholars, and staff of the Institute.

In the afternoon, the Institute organised a seminar on the theme "One Health, One Future: Integrating Science through Evidence, Innovations & Holistic Care." Professor (Dr) Ravichandiran V, Vice-Chancellor,

Delhi Pharmaceutical Sciences and Research University (DPSRU), was the chief guest of the programme. He congratulated AIIA for its efforts towards promoting Ayurveda globally and appreciated the Institute's initiatives. Dr Vinay Choudhary, Medical Officer, Department of AYUSH, Government of India, was the Guest of Honour. He

delivered a lecture on autoimmune disorders in clinical Ayurvedic practice. Professor (Vaidya) Pradeep Kumar Prajapati, Director, AIIA, emphasised the importance of collective participation in Ayurveda awareness initiatives and strengthening public engagement with Ayurveda as part of the Institute's outreach activities. Speaking on the occasion, he highlighted the initiatives AIIA undertook to mark Ayurveda Day.

He also informed that AIIA launched "AayurVarta," a special talk show dedicated to Ayurveda. The Institute organised AYURPRABHA-2026, a six-day workshop on Ayurveda Dermatology and Cosmetology, and conducted a special eye-screening camp for students of an NTPC school, among several other initiatives.

They also launched two books on the occasion: "Tarangini Sara Sangraha" and "Integrative Healthcare for Better Outcomes."

GDA holds 174th board meeting in Ghaziabad

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ghaziabad

The 174th Board Meeting of the Ghaziabad Development Authority (GDA) was held on Thursday at the Conference Hall of the GDA under the chairmanship of Bhanu Chandra Goswami, Commissioner, Meerut Division and Chairman of the Board.

The meeting was attended by Ravindra Kumar Mandar, District Magistrate, Ghaziabad; Kavita Meena, District Magistrate, Hapur; Nand Kishore Kalal, Vice-Chairman, GDA; Vikramaditya Singh Malik, Municipal Commissioner; Satish Kumar, Joint Director, Treasury and Pension, Meerut Division; Vishal Bharti, representative of CTPC and Chief Coordinator Planner, NCR Cell, Ghaziabad; and Pradeep Kumar Satyarthi, Regional Manager, UPSIDA. In addition, nominated Board members Keshav Tyagi and Pawan Goyal were also present.

The meeting witnessed detailed discussions and deliberations on several important proposals aimed at providing a new direction



to the present and future urban development of Ghaziabad.

The board meeting held detailed discussions on an important proposal concerning the development of an international cricket stadium. The proposal included acquisition of land owned by the Uttar Pradesh Cricket Association (UPCA) through land pooling, along with proceedings related to the Draft MoU and Feasibility Report for the construction of the stadium.

The project may also create new opportunities in sports training, promotion of local sporting talent, allied services and event manage-

ment. The Board held detailed discussions on the proposed new residential scheme of the Ghaziabad Development Authority, 'Haranadipuram', which is proposed to cover a total area of 501.2173 hectares.

Along with residential development, the scheme provides for commercial areas, community and social facilities, green and recreational spaces, and adequate provisions for transportation.

The Board discussed important proposals concerning the conversion of Group Housing plots in the Koyal Enclave Residential Scheme for Plotted

Development. One of the major plots measures 12,868.88 square metres, while another measures 2,020 square metres.

The Board also held detailed discussions on a proposal concerning the approved layout plan of Wave City. The proposal included land-use changes relating to a PSP plot measuring approximately 8,035.44 square metres in Sector-1, as well as a commercial plot measuring approximately 14,756.86 square metres.

Necessary modifications in land use and planning in accordance with actual requirements will facilitate more effective utilisation of available land in the developed area.

The board meeting considered a proposal relating to the approval of the layout plan for the first phase covering 589.02 acres under the revised DPR for the 'Suncity' Township, which has a revised total area of 2,420.11 acres.

The proposal was submitted under the Uttar Pradesh Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises Promotion Policy, 2022.

11th Ayurveda Day celebrations held across world

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The 11th Ayurveda Day was celebrated with enthusiasm across India and the world. The Grand National celebrations were held in Nagpur, Maharashtra. This year's theme was "Ayurveda for a Healthier Tomorrow". The programme witnessed the unveiling of key reports and documents, including the report on the Ayush Services Sector and "Ayush Vision 2030", along with the launch of the CCRAS-AGNI Web Portal. The event also featured scientific sessions on Ayurveda's role in healthcare and public health, as well as the roadmap towards 2047.

The programme read out the Prime Minister's message. In his message, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said that Ayurveda's journey from tradition to knowledge, evidence, and innovation will help secure the health and well-being of future generations. He highlighted that Ayurveda's identity has expanded beyond India's borders, with the AYUSH Visa facility enabling foreign nationals to seek treatment under Ayush systems in India.



Referring to the resolve of 'Shakti ki Sadhna', the Prime Minister said India is moving steadily towards a Viksit Bharat and expressed confidence that institutions, experts, and youth associated with Ayurveda will take this rich tradition to new heights and help build a healthy, capable, and strong nation.

The celebration ceremony was virtually inaugurated by Union Minister of State (Independent Charge), Ministry of AYUSH, and Minister of State, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Prataprao Jadhav, in the presence of Secretary,

Ministry of AYUSH, Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha; Director General, Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences (CCRAS), Professor (Vaidya) Rabinarayan Acharya, and other dignitaries.

Addressing the celebration, Union Minister described Ayurveda as a key part of India's health vision, saying, "The first centre of health is not a hospital, but our home. The first foundation of health is not medicine, but our lifestyle."

Secretary, Ministry of Ayush, Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha, emphasised that



DMRC's Director, Business Development Dr Pramit Kumar Garg was honoured with the Eminent Engineer's Award this year by the Institution of Engineers (Delhi State Centre). This prestigious award was conferred on Dr Garg on the occasion of Engineer's Day celebrations

PIONEER PHOTO

Children need social support after cancer treatment, say doctors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Childhood cancer treatment needs to address not just the disease but also the emotional and social needs of children as they regain confidence and return to everyday life, doctors said at an awareness programme in Delhi. The programme was organised by the Rajiv Gandhi Cancer Institute and Research Centre as part of Childhood Cancer Awareness Month, bringing together children undergoing treatment, survivors, caregivers and hospital staff.

According to an official statement, Gauri Kapoor, medical director at RGCIRC's Niti Bagh centre, said the needs of a child change through different stages of the cancer journey and that care must account for the period after intensive treatment as well.

"Childhood cancer care is a long journey, and every stage requires different kinds of support. Alongside treatment, children need opportunities to express themselves, regain confi-



dence, reconnect with everyday life," Kapoor said.

She said survivorship and wellbeing should remain an integral part of paediatric oncology care, rather than being treated as concerns that begin only after medical treatment has ended.

Dr Vineet Talwar, Medical Director, RGCIRC, added, "Advances in paediatric oncology have improved outcomes, but the journey does not end with treatment. Emotional wellbeing, rehabilitation, family support and long-term follow-up are equally important. Our focus is to ensure that every child receives

comprehensive care that supports not just recovery, but also a healthy and confident future."

The program, titled "One Journey, Many Hearts", included discussions on support for children and families, cultural activities, and participation by clinical, nursing, and administrative teams. The initiative also presented a plan to strengthen support during the treatment journey.

The event also brought caregivers and hospital teams together for interactive activities, while children participated in activities including nail art and tattoos.

Dharambir Kumar takes charge as POWERGRID NERTS head

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shillong

Power Grid Corporation of India Limited (POWERGRID), a Maharatna CPSE under the Ministry of Power, Government of India, has appointed Dharambir Kumar, Executive Director (ED), as head of the North Eastern Region Transmission System (NERTS), effective 18 September 2026.

Dharambir Kumar joined POWERGRID in January 1994 and has over 32 years of experience in the power transmission sector. He holds a B.Sc. in Electrical Engineering from BR Ambedkar Bihar University, Muzaffarpur and was promoted to the position of Executive Director in July 2026.



During his long tenure with POWERGRID, Dharambir Kumar has served in various capacities across the North Eastern and Eastern Regions, as well as at corporate and regional offices. His experience includes substation maintenance and operation, consultancy, transmission line and substation projects, and project execution. He has also served at Jiribam and Seppa in the North Eastern Region, as well as on assignments in Ranchi, Jamshedpur, Gurgaon, Rajasthan, and other locations.

कार्यालय उज्जैन नगर पालिक निगम, उज्जैन
छत्रपति शिवाजी भवन आगर रोड उज्जैन
(Online) निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना



विज्ञप्ति क्र./ 1863

उज्जैन दिनांक :- 22/9/26

निम्नांकित कार्य के लिए प्रपत्र 'अ' (फार्म ए) में प्रतिलिपि कम या अधिक के आधार पर प्रमुख अभियंता लोक निर्माण विभाग म.प्र. शासन भोपाल के कार्यालय में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से उक्त विभाग में पंजीयन प्रमाण पत्र की प्रमाणाति प्रति प्रस्तुत करने पर ऑनलाइन (Online) निविदा आह्वानित की जाती हैं, तथा ठेकेदार की (श्रेणी सी) एम.पी.गवर्नमेंट व सिरियल क्र. 1 का टेंडर फार्म मूल्य 30,000/- रहेगा।

सिरियल क्र. 1 आनलाइन क्रय करने की अंतिम दिनांक 22.10.2026 समय 17:00, ऑनलाइन ई.एम.डी. राशि एवं समस्त दस्तावेज Submission करने की अंतिम दिनांक 22.10.2026 समय 17:00 रहेगी।

विस्तृत निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना एवं अन्य जानकारी वेबसाइट www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखी जा सकती हैं। यदि उपरोक्त निविदा में किसी प्रकार का संशोधन होता है तो इसकी सूचना ऑन लाइन दी जाएगी। पृथक से समाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित नहीं की जाएगी।

क्र	टेंडर क्रमांक	कार्य का नाम	अनुमानित लागत	नगरीय प्रशासन एवं विकास विभाग म.प्र. भोपाल	अन्र्दमनी रु.	समय अवधि
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	2026_UAD_537839_1	वीरदुर्गादास मार्ग (जूना सोमवारीया) से कार्तिक चौक तक चौड्डीकरण कार्य	17,68,84,137/-	02-08-2021 and 08-11-2025 UADD ISSR SOR AND ITEN RATE	8,84,420/-	365 दिन

प्रतिलिपि :-
1. माननीय महापौर जी की ओर निज सचिव के माध्यम से अलोकनाथ प्रेषित।
क्रमांक:- 11864

कार्यपालक खंत्री
नगर पालिक निगम उज्जैन
दिनांक : 22/9/26



The Delhi Metro International Limited (DMIL), a wholly owned subsidiary of Delhi Metro, participated in InnoTrans 2026, one of the world's largest events in the transportation sector. D Thara, Secretary, Department of Capital Development, Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Government of India, inaugurated DMIL's exhibition pavilion in the presence of senior officials from DMRC and DMIL

PIONEER PHOTO

BRIEFLY

Indian men, women kabaddi teams favourites at Asiad semis



Defending champions India stormed into the men's and women's kabaddi semi-finals with resounding wins over Chinese Taipei and Japan in their Group A fixtures here on Thursday.

While the Indian men defeated Chinese Taipei 37-21 win over Chinese Taipei in their final Group A fixture, the Indian women beat hosts Japan 50-25 to top their group. The victory was Indian men's fourth consecutive in the group stage, where the side earlier defeated South Korea, Japan and Bangladesh to sign off unbeaten and be assured of at least a bronze.

India dominated from the outset, taking a 23-11 lead at half-time before maintaining their advantage in the second half, which they won 14-10. (PTI)

Bhavani Devi, Shreya Gupta bow out in fencing at Asiad



India's fencing campaign at the Asian Games ended without a medal as C A Bhavani Devi and Shreya Gupta were eliminated in the women's individual sabre event here on Thursday. Bhavani, India's first fencer to compete at the Olympics, advanced to the round of 16 after defeating Mongolia's Oulen Tugsjargan 15-8 in the round of 32.

However, the 32-year-old Indian ran into a tough opponent in China's Rao Xueyi and went down 5-15 in the pre-quarterfinals. Rao, the silver medallist at the 2026 World Championships, took control early and led 8-2 at the end of the first period before completing a comfortable victory.

Shreya received a direct passage to the round of 16 after finishing third in Pool 2 but could not make further progress, losing to South Korea's Jeon Ha-young. (PTI)

Roshibina wins silver in Asiad wushu

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH/
AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

Skeet shooters once again rescued a faltering campaign at the ranges, the beleaguered rowers signed off with a face-saving bronze while wushu player Roshibina Devi collected her second successive silver to silence the naysayers on an eventful day for India at the Asian Games here on Thursday.

India's campaign across sports has been far from convincing so far in the showpiece. The medal count has increased to 15 but features only one gold that came through women's cricket team.

The biggest letdown by a considerable margin have been the shooters and Thursday's

script was no different. After women's air pistol squad drew a blank the previous day, the men too came a cropper as they finished fourth in the team event with neither of the three making individual finals.

It could well have been a barren day but for the mixed team skeet bronze by Parinaaz Dhaliwal and Anantjeet Singh Naruka, both of whom have also claimed bronze medals in women's and men's team competitions earlier.

The embattled rowers, who have

been complaining about last-minute changes to combinations and threats from the Rowing Federation of India, finally had something to show for with Satnam Singh and Salman Khan combining to win the men's double skulls bronze.

The Indian pair stayed in second place until the 1,500m mark before slipping to third in the final 500m, clocking 6:13.25 at Nagaragawa International Regatta Course to finish 3.88 seconds behind gold-medallists China. "We only came together in the men's double skulls five days ago. I feel proud that, after only five days

together, we have managed to win an Asian Games medal in this event," said Satnam.

Roshibina, meanwhile became India's most successful wushu player in Asian Games history with her second successive silver and overall third successive medal at quadrennial showpiece. She lost to Zhang Xiaoyu of China in the women's 60kg final. Roshibina had lost trials for the event but injury to original choice

Divyanshi opened window for her.

She made full use of it despite negativity of Divyanshi's allegations that the federation played favourites. "It's all right if somebody wants to be negative to me. In every situation you have to be strong and ignore negative environment and just trust yourself and bring your best energy," she said. (PTI)



ROSHIBINA BECAME INDIA'S MOST SUCCESSFUL WUSHU PLAYER IN ASIAD WITH SECOND SUCCESSIVE SILVER

Satnam-Salman wins India's maiden bronze in men's double skulls

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH
■ Nagoya

Satnam Singh and Salman Khan's double skulls bronze turned out to be the saving grace as the embattled Indian rowing team produced one of the worst performances in the Asian Games history here on Thursday.

The duo's bronze was India's first ever men's double skulls medal at the continental games.

Rowing competitions were introduced in the 1982 Asian Games, and India won the most medals in the 2010 Guangzhou and 2023 Hangzhou editions. India had won five medals in 2010, including one gold, three silver and one bronze. The number remained the same in 2023 but there was no gold in the tally as the rowers logged two silver and three bronze medals.

The 2018 Games yielded three podium finishes, including one gold.

This edition's performance equalled that of the year 1982, 1994 and 2002 edi-



tions.

The Indian pair stayed in second place until the 1,500m mark before slipping to third in the final 500m, clocking 6:13.25 at the Nagaragawa International Regatta Course.

China's Yi Xudi and Yide Nie won the gold medal with a timing of 6:09.37, while Uzbekistan's Pavel Sorin and Mekhrobek Mamatkulov claimed silver after clocking 6:10.49. The Indian duo finished 3.88 seconds behind the gold medallists. Prime Minister Narendra

Modi lauded duo after the feat. (PTI)

Start was shaky but we kept backing each other: Anantjeet after mixed team bronze

AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

A shaky start left Anantjeet Singh Naruka and Parinaaz Dhaliwal staring at an early exit, but the Indian skeet pair refused to buckle, pushing each other through the pressure to fight until the last target and secure a historic bronze in the mixed team event at the Asian Games here on Thursday.

The medal was India's first-ever in the Asian Games skeet mixed team event and capped a remarkable fightback after Naruka and Dhaliwal managed just 44/50 in the opening round of qualification.

"We had a difficult start. Both of us didn't shoot well in the first round and then we just told each other that we can still get it. We have two more rounds to go and we will fight till the last target," Naruka said.

The Indians responded exactly as they had promised. They steadied themselves in the second round, hitting 47 targets, and matched that score in the third to finish qualification on 138 and book their place in the four-team final.

Dhaliwal said the message between them never changed: keep fighting and worry about the



result only after the last target. "It was just about fighting till the very end. We were like, 'Let's just give it our all and then we'll see what happens after the third round,' and that's what we did," she said.

For Naruka, that mutual support

kept the atmosphere upbeat rather than allowing the pressure to build.

"We were just having a really happy environment and we were just like, 'We are going to do this. We don't know how, but I know we will end up doing this,'" Dhaliwal said. (PTI)

Spain's World Cup-winning stars are built different and cannot be copied: Gordon

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Burton-on-Trent (England)

England would be making a mistake by trying to replicate Spain's successful style of play in a bid to win major tournaments, winger Anthony Gordon said ahead of Saturday's match between the European giants. Gordon is well-placed to discuss the qualities of Spain's World Cup-winning players, given he now trains daily with many of them - like Rodri, Lamine Yamal, Pedri and more - following his offseason move to La Liga champion Barcelona. "They're definitely built different," Gordon said. "So I'm not sure we can ever get that."

Long-held doubts over England's ability to end the men's team's long wait to win a European Championship or



World Cup returned over the summer when England squandered a lead - earned by a goal from Gordon - by conceding two late goals to lose 2-1 to Argentina

in WC semifinals.

Gordon said he might never get over the defeat that has prompted questions over whether England's players have the quality to control these high-pressure games like the Spanish can. That's because England became ultra-defensive after taking the lead - Gordon was replaced by a defender, Ezri Konsa, in a telling substitution by coach Thomas Tuchel - and allowed Argentina to seize the initiative in the final half-hour.

Gordon was asked, couldn't England just be more like Spain?

"I think culturally, it's not just that tournament or game where we couldn't control a game," he said.

Antonelli aims to stay on target for F1 title in Baku year after Piastri's challenge crumbled

JAMES ELLINGWORTH
■ Baku (Azerbaijan)

Kimi Antonelli insists the Formula 1 title race is "not over" as he takes a vast 81-point lead into this week's Azerbaijan Grand Prix. It looks as good as over, but Baku has sprung surprises before. A year ago, that was where Oscar Piastri's title shot began to fall apart. The Australian was leading the standings when he almost stalled on the grid, dropped to last and crashed, all in space of about a minute on opening lap.

That kicked off a run of six races without a podium finish for Piastri, who had to watch the title race become a fight between eventual champion



Lando Norris and Max Verstappen.

Antonelli - whose practice was hampered by car problems Thursday - is sounding cautious as he aims to become F1's youngest-ever champion.

"Until you cross that finish

line, it's not over. It's like tennis, one point at a time, here one race at a time," he said. "The sooner it's over, better it is. Still a long way and it's not going to be easy. It's going to be intense but I'm ready to give my best and to keep having fun." (AP)

DAILY SUDOKU

3					7		8
				7		3	
5		7	2		4		
		3	6				9
6		9			8		4
8				1	5		
		5		6	1		7
	4		5				
9		8					5

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

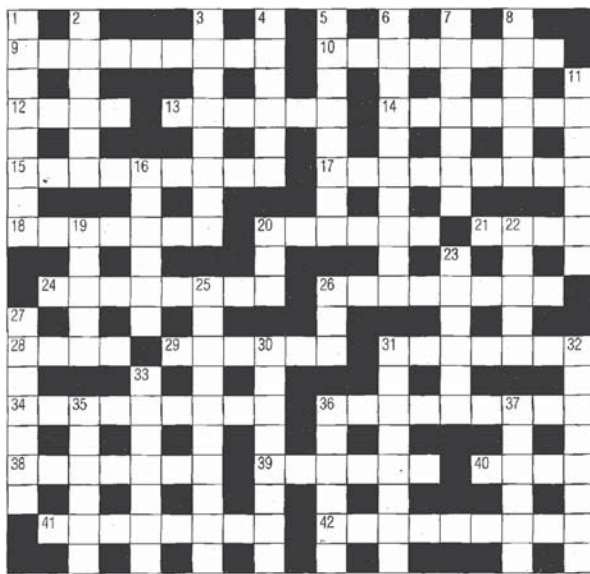
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction - no maths involved.



SOLUTION (24.9.26)

7	3	2	8	1	9	4	6	5
6	9	5	4	3	7	2	8	1
8	4	1	2	5	6	9	7	3
1	5	7	3	9	4	6	2	8
4	8	6	7	2	5	1	3	9
9	2	3	6	8	1	5	4	7
5	6	4	1	7	3	8	9	2
3	1	8	9	4	2	7	5	6
2	7	9	5	6	8	3	1	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | SEPTEMBER 25, 2026



ACROSS

- 9 Acquired in hospital and acquired illicitly? (3-6)
10 With the wind having died down, will cease (4,4)
12 "Hello," said the drunk (4)
13 Knock unconscious - that's the plan (6)
14 I got near it, struggling against lethargy
15 Driving the new car when taking to the station (7,2)
17 Attacker the alsatians put to flight (9)
18 The policeman did volunteer to hold in charge (7)
20 Rabbit the infant may enjoy playing with (6)
21 Contend there's a boom (4)
24 There's a section in about South Africa

DOWN

- 1 Before this strike and the other disruption (8)
2 The bottle the fellow took along has broken (6)
3 Being a newcomer, is more curious (8)
4 Having yet to see the light (6)
5 Steal - but that's immaterial (8)
6 Does a music student find it invigorating? (5,5)
7 Set for bed before I come in (7)
8 A bed and on it a girl (6)
11 Act up, becoming rowdy again, in apprehension (7)
16 Egg on, showing sound perception (6)
19 Former girlfriend who was a red? (5)
20 Manage to flee (3)

that's biased (8)

- 26 The getting in early may be hard (8)
28 As a concept, it's less than perfect (4)
29 Annoyed that the blouse is masculine-looking? (6)
31 In order to fend off a member of the team (7)
34 So big it's just horrible? (9)
36 Composed personally, when alone (2,7)
38 Commission the girl got on the weapon
39 How the restaurant critic criticises them? (6)
40 Waken up when there's a storm (4)
41 Will get one back into shape? Go on! (8)
42 It's cut for a card game (9)

- 22 Capturing the royal parents in an Italian city (5)
23 Be given credit for the attack (6)
25 The strain you associate with studies, as a youngster (6,4)
26 Song birds do (3)
27 Do they like cheese mixed with their birdseed? (7)
30 Rather unapproachable, is engaged (8)
31 How you smiled at the hoary old joke? (8)
32 The bench is indeed misshapen (8)
33 Opens up when I am in difficulties (7)
35 "Thought to be unfeasible," I put in (6)
36 A strident "Alloy has a Y on the end!"
37 Necessitate changing a ten to forty-nine (6)

SOLUTION (24.9.26)

- ACROSS
4, Snatch
7, Upper-cut
8, Apples
10, Swish
13, Plus
14, Tish
15, Bolt
16, Be-E
17, Over
19, Sa-I-d
21, Point's out
23, Disc
24, Rang
26, Di-p
27, Toad
29, Em-it
32, Toby
33, Prone
34, Retire
35, Swans-on-G
36, Strafe
DOWN
1, Bu-R-st
2, Ap-his
3, Arch
4, 5-tall
5, Alps
6, Crewed
9, Pu-tso-n
11, W-OK
12, Shoos
13, Port-ray
15, B-EN
16, Bit
18, Victor
20, Auger
21, Pip
22, Sad
23, Diver-t
25, Bin
28, O-bese
30, MOT-O-R
31, Teign
32, Tina
33, Punt

Asiad Hockey: India beat Korea 8-2

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kakamigahara (Japan)

In-form striker Dilpreet Singh fired a hat-trick to hand the Indian men's hockey team a comfortable 8-2 win over Korea and all but assure its place in the semifinal of the Asian Games here on Thursday. It was India's third consecutive win, keeping them at the top of pool A. India had earlier thrashed Indonesia 13-1 and Sri Lanka 16-1 in their opening two pool matches. Dilpreet (10th, 26th, 32nd minutes) continued his impressive form and scored three fine field goals, while Abhishek (15th, 38th) struck a brace. Shilanand Lakra (4th), skipper Harmanpreet Singh (11th) and Rajinder Singh (60th) were the other goal getters for India.

Korea's goals were scored by Kim Jae Ho (42nd) and Kim Yong Bok (52nd). Defending champions India will next play hosts Japan on Saturday. The Indians started on an aggressive note and never let Korea settle down. It took just four minutes for India to take the lead through



Shilanand, who tapped in an incredible aerial ball into the box from vice-captain Hardik Singh. India doubled their lead in the 10th minute through in-form Dilpreet, who slammed home with a fierce shot from top of the circle from a Mandeep Singh assist. Skipper Harmanpreet made it 3-0, ramming home a penalty corner with a powerful drag-flick to the left of the Korean goalkeeper a minute later.

Abhishek then pushed in an assist from Shilaland in the final

minute of the first quarter. India continued to dominate in the second quarter, and scored one more goal when Dilpreet tapped in a backhand cross from Mandeep.

Two minutes after the change of ends, India extended their lead through Dilpreet, who this time slammed home with a beautiful tomahawk after fine one-two between Mandeep and Hardik. Minutes later India secured four consecutive penalty corners but failed to utilise them. Korea soon

got their first penalty corner but India defended stoutly. Abhishek extended India's lead to 7-0, scoring from a rebound after Sukhjeet Singh's initial try was kept out by Korean goalkeeper Kim Jaehan.

Korea finally managed to pull a goal back against the run of play through Kim Jae Ho, three minutes from the third quarter.

The Koreans came out with more purpose in the fourth and final quarter, pressing hard on the Indian defence and in the process secured two penalty corners in quick succession but failed to breach the Indian defence. Korea found the Indian net again in eight minutes from the hooter when Kim Yong Bok beat three Indian defenders before slamming home with a rasping shot.

India converted a penalty corner through Rajinder just seconds from the hooter.



More medals will only grow Indian women's cricket: Shafali



SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Star opening batter Shafali Verma believes Indian women's cricket is on an upward trend and will only grow with more medals and trophies.

Shafali played an instrumental role in the women's team defending its gold medal at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games in Japan. Shafali was the top scorer at the Asian Games with 188 runs (an average of 188 and a strike rate over 200), which included a 49-ball century against Bangladesh in the semifinals. She played a useful innings of 40 runs against Japan in the quarterfinals and a sterling 48-run knock in the final against Sri Lanka. India decimated Sri Lanka by 147 runs in the final, after crushing Bangladesh by 114 runs in the semifinals, and trounced Japan by eight wickets.

"I am very happy that India won the gold medal and that the tricolour was flying high. The full team is so happy. The more medals we win and the more trophies we clinch, the more our women's cricket will grow. And that is why I am so happy about," Shafali told PTI upon

SHAFAI PLAYED AN INSTRUMENTAL ROLE IN THE WOMEN'S TEAM DEFENDING ITS GOLD MEDAL AT THE AICHI-NAGOYA ASIAN GAMES IN JAPAN

returning from Japan in the wee hours here on Thursday.

Shafali returned with the gold medal along with some teammates, including team's captain Harmanpreet Kaur, all-rounder Deepti Sharma, left-arm orthodox spinner Radha Yadav and batter Pratika Rawal.

While the captain, Deepti and Radha chose not to speak to the media due to certain BCCI protocol issues, Pratika made herself available for a brief chat with the waiting reporters at the airport. "I am extremely happy that the team has done extremely well. This is what we wanted to do. We wanted to get a gold medal and the team has executed itself very well. The entire country is happy and cheers to everyone," Pratika, who didn't play a single match, told reporters.

Satwik-Chirag eye another gold in Asian Games badminton



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Nagoya

Lakshya Sen and PV Sindhu face a stern test after being handed challenging draws, while defending champions Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty got a relatively favourable route to the semifinals as the focus shifts to the individual competitions following the team championships at the Asian Games, beginning here on Friday.

India managed to secure back-to-back medals at the Asian Games after the men's team signed off with a bronze following a silver in the last edition at Hangzhou, China.

It was a 1-3 loss to China in the semifinals which saw India settle for a bronze on Wednesday. The loss can be attributed to the failure of the singles player as both Lakshya Sen and Ayush Shetty lost their respective matches. It was a similar story in women's team championships as PV Sindhu and Unnati Hooda came a cropper against Japanese counterparts in the quarterfinals to return without a medal. The single stars will have to quickly recover from the disappointment and regroup as they train their guns at an individual medal at the 20th edition of the quadrennial showcase.

World No. 14 Lakshya had come into the competition



after a series of first-round exits but showed tremendous grit to see off double world championships silver medallist Kodai Narko in the quarterfinals. But he couldn't sustain the same pressure against China's Shi Yu Qi in the semifinals.

Lakshya, who received a first-round bye, will open his campaign against former world champion Loh K ean Yew of Singapore in the second round. Things will not get any easier as the 25-year-old from Almora could then face world No. 1 Jonatan Christie of Indonesia in the quarterfinals if he surpasses Loh. Ayush, who had stunned Shi Yu Qi at the New Delhi World Championships, has also been handed a first-round bye but faces a difficult third-round assignment against Chou Tien Chen of Chinese Taipei if he progresses. Two-time Olympic medallist Sindhu, like Lakshya, will begin in the second round after receiving a bye.

Anahat, Tanvi set up all-Indian quarterfinal; Abhay, Veer, Joshna-Senthil also advance

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Nagoya

India enjoyed a productive day on the squash courts at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games here on Thursday, with Anahat Singh, Tanvi Khanna, Abhay Singh and Veer Chotrani advancing to the singles quarterfinals, while Joshna Chinappa and Velavan Senthilkumar also making the mixed doubles last-eight.

Junior world champion and medal favourite Anahat began her women's singles campaign with a 3-0 (11-4, 11-5, 11-7) win over Singapore's Wai Lynn Au Yeong in just 19 minutes.

Tanvi then joined her teenage compatriot in the quarterfinals after beating Singapore's Wai Yhann Au



Yeong 3-1 (5-11, 11-4, 11-5, 13-11) in 39 minutes. The results set up an all-Indian women's singles quarterfinal between Anahat and Tanvi.

Unlike last edition, semifinalists are not assured of a guaranteed medal in the squash singles competition.

Five days, no gold: India's shooting struggles deepen at Asiad Games

AJAI MASAND ■ Nagoya

India's shooting struggles at the Asian Games deepened on Thursday as the men's 10m air pistol team, which is traditionally one of the country's strongest disciplines, drew a blank here.



Kamaljeet, Aakash Bhardwaj and Kedarling Uchaganve all missed the eight-shooter final, leaving India empty-handed in an event in which the nation was expected to challenge for a medal. Kamaljeet came agonisingly close, finishing ninth with 580 — just one point short of the qualification mark — while Bhardwaj shot 579 to finish 11th. Kedarling endured a nightmare outing, finishing 35th with 568. India's combined score of 1727 was enough for fourth place, but Japan, who had trailed for much of the competition, seized their opportunity when Kedarling's scores began to dip sharply and surged into the bronze-medal position with 1730.

It was another disappointing day for an Indian contingent that has now completed five days of shooting without a gold medal — an unusual drought for the Asian powerhouse even though four silver and three bronze medals have been secured by it. The result came a day after India's star-studded women's 10m air pistol team of double Olympic-medallist Manu Bhaker and World Cup gold-medallists Esha Singh and Suruchi Singh also failed to make the final.

Speed climbers Joga and Deepu Mallesh gear up for Asiad debut

POONAM MEHRA
■ New Delhi

Debuts can be terrifying but for speed climbers Joga Purty and Deepu Mallesh, the thought of representing India at the Asian Games for the first time is more exhilarating than intimidating.

The 19-year-old Joga and experienced 28-year-old Deepu will present India's challenge in the niche sport that has been a part of the Asiad only since 2018 and became an Olympic event in the Tokyo 2020 edition.

In an exclusive interview to PTI, the two youngsters talked about their journeys and the challenges of picking up the sport before heading for the Asiad where their competitions will begin on



September 29. India is yet to win a climbing medal at the showpiece.

"I knew nothing about sport climbing. I had gone to see the Tata Steel Adventure Foundation (TSAF) Sport Climbing Academy (in Jamshedpur) with my brother and a few friends, who were into climbing.



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